

The Rise and Fall of the Capitalist World-System (II): The Internal Structure of Transnational Production Capitalism

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II. Transnational Production: The New Stage of Global Capitalism

1. From the Transnationalisation of Relations of Production to the Transnationalisation of the Mode of Production

As we said in the first chapter, modern capitalism was born in the world market, so — as Marx wrote in the Communist Manifesto — "The need of a constantly expanding market for its products chases the bourgeoisie over the entire surface of the globe. It must nestle everywhere, settle everywhere, establish connexions everywhere." That is, from the very beginning the capitalist did not produce only for his own country but for the globe. Since capitalism was transnational from the start, what reason is there to think that today's transnational bourgeoisie differs in any essential way from the transnational bourgeoisie of a hundred years ago?

In fact, corresponding to the three stages of the capitalist world-system, the development of capitalist production has also gone through three stages: the transnationalisation of exchange, the globalisation of the relations of production, and the globalisation of the mode of production.

In the first stage, productive capital remained confined within the nation. In the heyday of commercial capitalism, Western capitalists in the East mostly invested in trading companies or shipyards and other trade-related businesses; factories of manufacture were rare. Capitalist production took place within each country; the social form of wage-labour production, capital, was also distributed among the countries. Because in this period the dominant forms of capital were commercial capital and finance capital, and industrial capital was relatively weak at home — let alone

across borders — it was very rare for a country's manufactory capitalist to invest in industry in another country. In the colonies, the West European countries' production, apart from the native ancient modes of production and the small production of immigrants, was chiefly slavery — not capitalist production.

In fact, the bourgeois states, in order to develop their own manufacturing, also worked to de-industrialise other countries. As Marx points out in *Capital*: "The protective tariff system was an artificial means of manufacturing manufacturers, of expropriating independent labourers, of capitalising the national means of production and subsistence, of forcibly abbreviating the transition from the mediaeval to the modern mode of production... The European states tore one another's patents for this invention of theirs; and, once entered into the service of the profit-mongers, they not only called down upon the heads of their own peoples a heavy contribution of capital for this purpose, through protective duties and direct export premiums, but they forcibly destroyed all industry in their subsidiary countries, as, for example, England destroyed the woollen manufacture of Ireland."^[1]

Thus, in the first stage of the capitalist world-system, capitalist relations of production remained within one country, but exchange relations were internationalised.

When the capitalist world-system reached the stage of national industrial capitalism, capitalist production aimed still more at destroying the manufacturing of other countries. Britain's destruction of India's textile industry, introduced in the first chapter, is the most typical example. As for China, it was only after the Western capitalist countries had completed their industrial and transport revolutions that they were able to destroy China's industry:

In 1840, Western cotton cloth still could not compete with Chinese cotton cloth, so high tariffs were used to keep Chinese cloth out and protect the textile industry — the most important sector of the Industrial Revolution. After France and Britain signed a preferential agreement in 1850 greatly lowering tariffs, France still levied 15% tariffs on British textiles to protect its own industry. But France levied 30% tariffs on Chinese textile imports, making it almost impossible for Chinese textiles to enter France. America's tariff on Chinese cotton cloth was 25 times China's tariff on American cloth. In such circumstances, how could Chinese products compete? The greatest change came after the Second Industrial Revolution. By then, British industrial production had been mechanised, and with the opening of the Suez Canal, the price of British cloth shipped to China fell sharply. Cheap and good, British cotton cloth, once exported to China, destroyed China's traditional cotton textile industry. Zheng Guanying, the famous Qing entrepreneur, wrote a book called *Warnings to a Prosperous Age* (Shengshi Weiyan), which greatly influenced early-twentieth-century Chinese — Mao Zedong was deeply struck by this book in his youth. Zheng wrote: "Foreign cloth, foreign yarn, foreign lace, foreign mending, foreign towels enter China, and women's handicrafts lose their work; kerosene, foreign candles, foreign electricity enter China, and the tallow trees of the southeastern provinces are no longer timber; foreign iron, foreign needles, foreign nails enter China, and smiths are idle. These are

the great ones; the lesser ones are too many to enumerate. The reason: foreign countries use machines, so the work is fine and cheap, and succeeds; China uses manual labour, so the work is clumsy and dear, and succeeds with difficulty. The livelihoods of the Chinese people have all been seized." Foreign goods entered China without tariff protection, so China's traditional industry and agriculture were finished. Mr. Wu Chengming estimated that the imported foreign yarn and cloth alone equalled 800 million manual labour days, causing millions of unemployed. China's abundant labour force turned from an advantage into a disadvantage.^[2]

When the capital of the Western capitalist countries had accumulated to a certain extent and formed over-accumulation, they began the transition from free capitalism to monopoly capitalism. In the countries that had entered monopoly capitalism, i.e. imperialism, huge amounts of surplus capital appeared. This capital, finding no outlet for investment at home, flowed abroad. On this process, Lenin gave a classic formulation:

Approaching the twentieth century, we see the formation of another kind of monopoly: first, monopoly alliances of capitalists in all developed capitalist countries; second, the monopolistic position of the few richest countries with colossal capital accumulation. Large quantities of "surplus capital" appeared in the advanced countries. As long as capitalism remains capitalism, surplus capital will not be used to raise the living standard of the masses of the home country (for that would lower the capitalists' profits), but will be exported abroad, to backward countries, to raise profits. In these backward countries, profits are usually high, because capital is scarce, land prices are relatively low, wages are low, and raw materials are cheap. The possibility of exporting capital is created by the fact that many backward countries have been drawn into world capitalist circulation, main railway lines have been built or are being built, elementary conditions for industrial development have been assured, etc. The necessity of exporting capital arises from the fact that in a few countries capitalism has become "over-ripe," and (owing to the backwardness of agriculture and the impoverished state of the masses) "profitable" investment fields are lacking. — Lenin, *Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism*

Lenin's book gives a wealth of statistics and examples of capital export. From the Chinese point of view, it was indeed around the transition of capitalism to imperialism that Western and Japanese capitalists, no longer content with exporting goods to China, demanded to export capital — investing in China's transport, public utilities, and manufacturing. According to the relevant statistics^[3], the imperialist countries also invested heavily in Mexico and elsewhere. But apart from infrastructure such as railways and electricity, most of these investments were in industries processing local raw materials (like silk) for export, or light industries serving the local market.

Not only did the imperialist countries invest heavily in the peripheral countries; investment among the imperialist countries themselves was also very common. So by the imperialist stage, capitalist production had become transnational at the level of the relations of production. The transnational

bourgeoisie existed by then. The American bourgeoisie had large investments in Nazi Germany, and many American companies aided the Nazi regime^{[4][5]}.

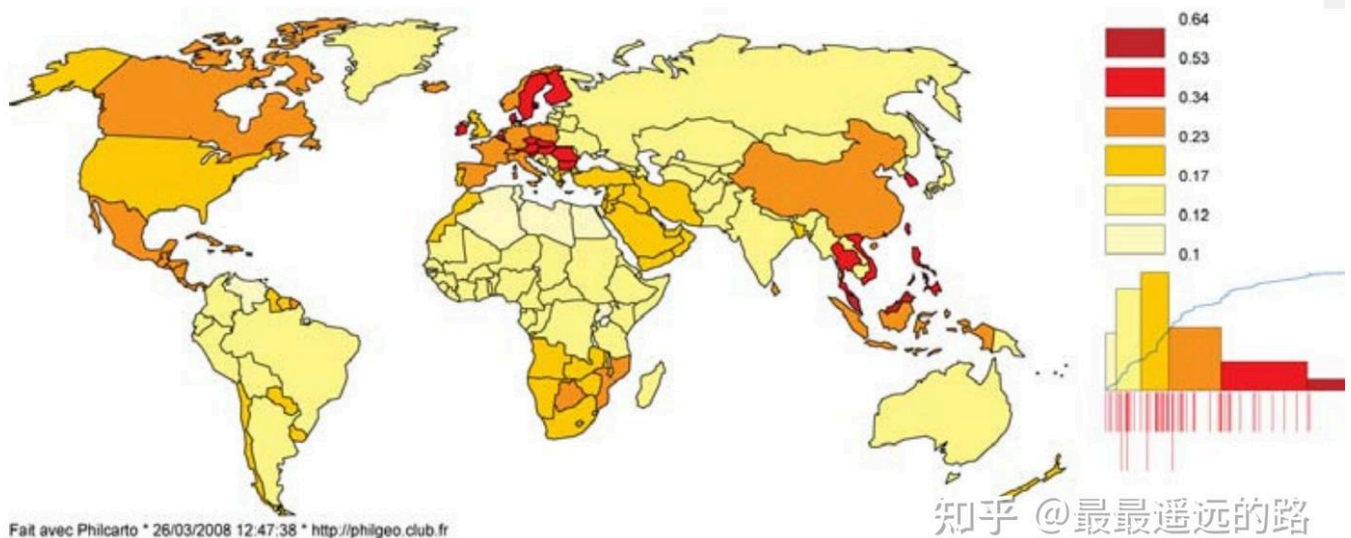
However, because of shipping costs and the abundance of domestic industrial labour, whether in the peripheral or the centre countries, transnational enterprises still relied mainly on local supply chains; even where key components or materials were imported, the share was low. In this period, it was rare for the intermediate products of the various production stages of a commodity to cross borders back and forth.

Thus, in the second stage of the capitalist world, on the basis of the further development of the transnationalisation of exchange, the transnationalisation of the relations of production appeared; but the material mode of production was still based in one country — production was not yet globalised in the true sense.

In the third stage of the capitalist world-system, in which we now live, capitalist production has become transnational and global at the level of the material mode of production, forming global value chains. The manufacturing links of the industrial chain are divided into different stages; the product of each stage becomes the intermediate input of the next; labour value flows around the globe with the products. The multinational corporation achieves profit maximisation by vertically integrating all the enterprises on the globally distributed value chain.

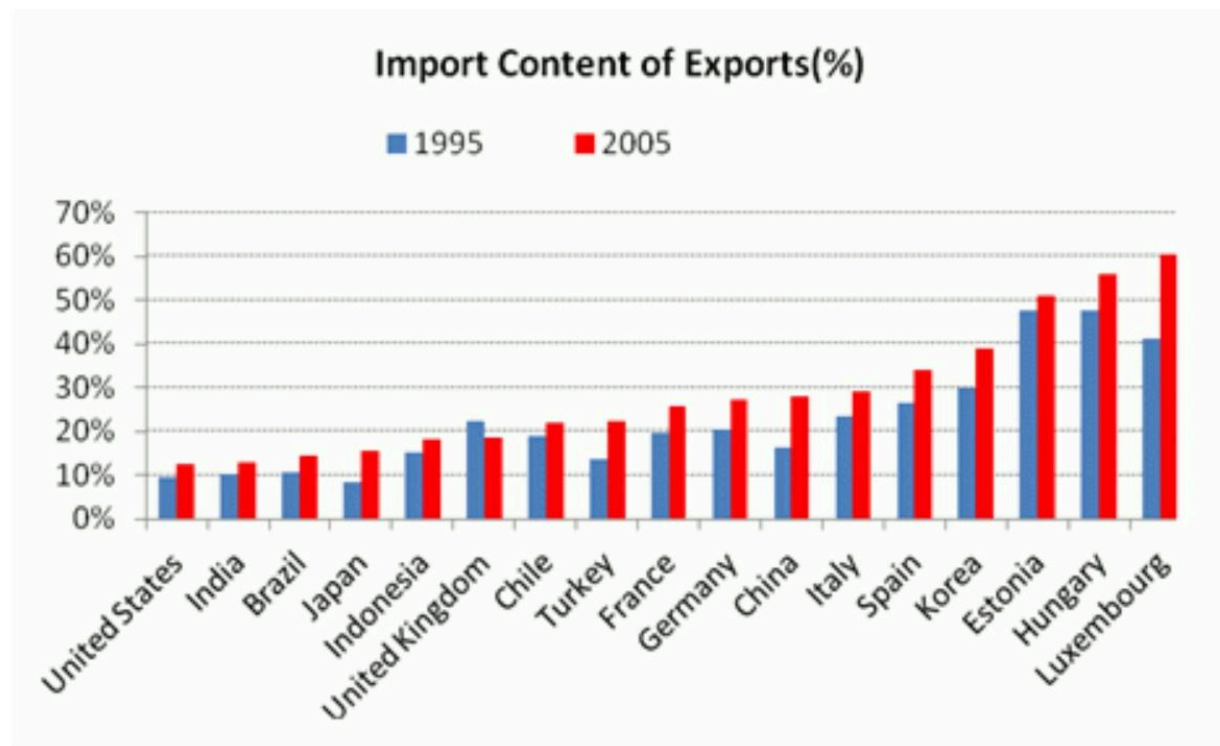
As shown below^[6], Southeast Asia participates deeply in vertical integration.

Map 2: Share of vertical exports in total exports



The chart below^[7]:

Figure 1. Imported content of exports



Source: OECD IO Database

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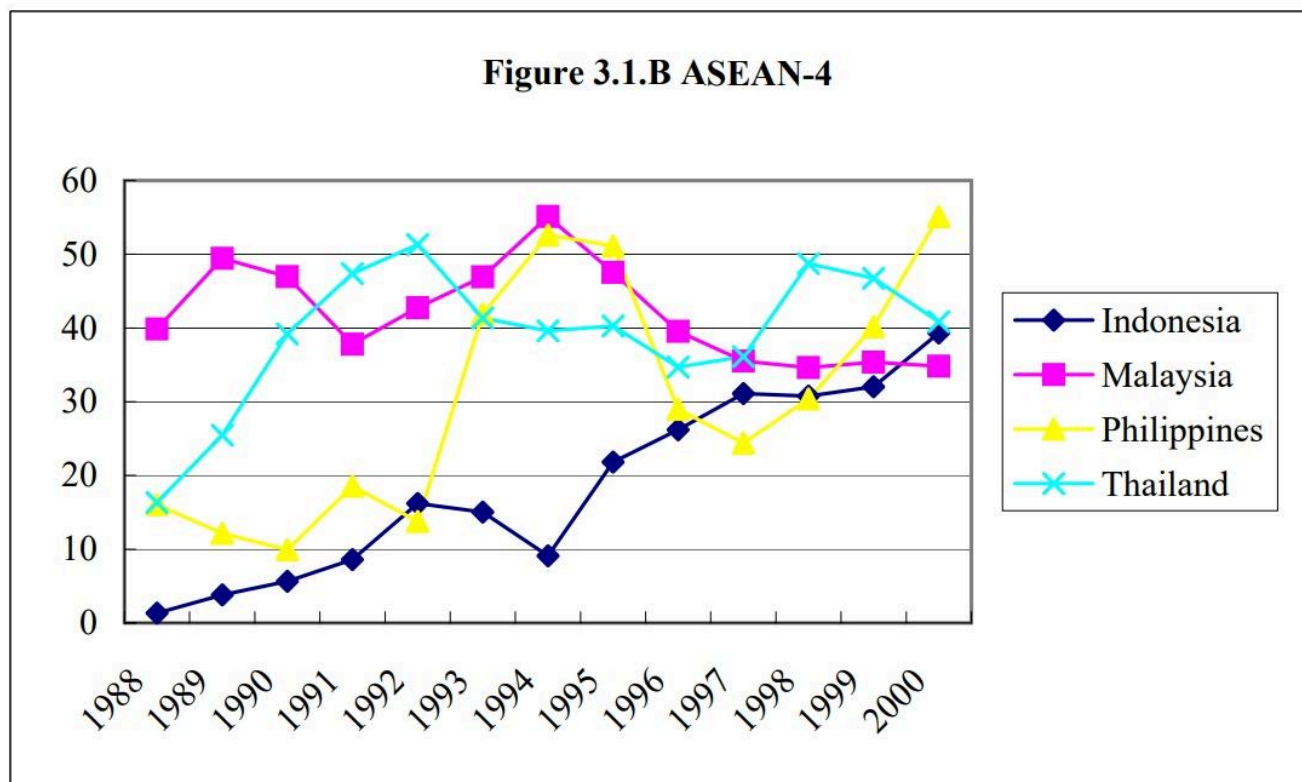
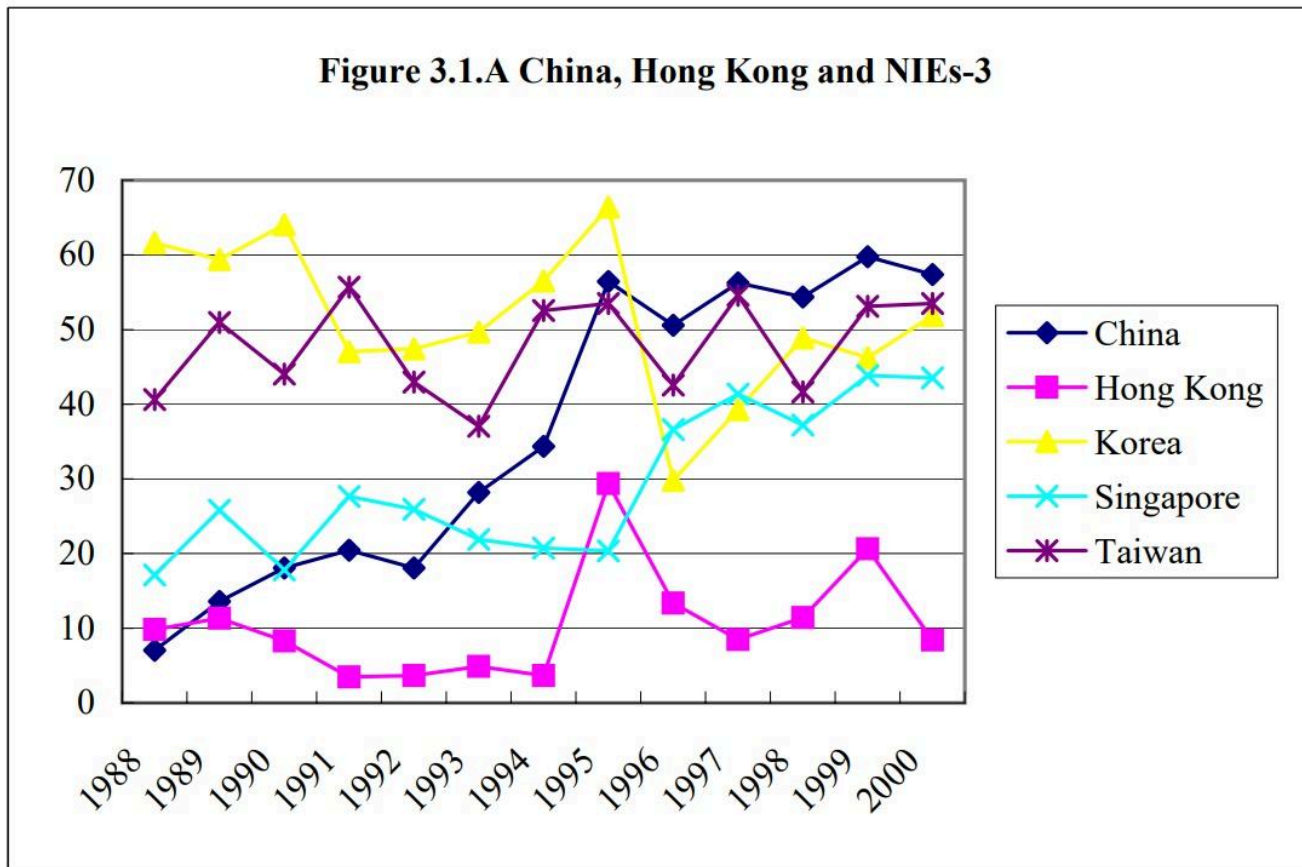
The transnationalisation — the globalisation — of the mode of production makes the production of all countries interdependent. Japan's and America's dependence on China is proof; this dependence extends even to the field of national defence. Supply-chain interdependence has developed to such a point that the great powers use supply chains as weapons of political struggle.

The Japanese government's 2024 edition of the Trade White Paper, released on the 9th, shows that among Japan's import sources, more than half of the import value of 1,406 product categories came from China — 2.5 times the figure for America. The Nikkei analyses that this reflects the high dependence of Japan's supply chains on China^[8]. According to Japan's Energy and Metals Mineral Resources Agency, in 2024 China's rare earths accounted for 71.9% of Japan's total rare-earth imports. The 2026 Catalogue for the Administration of Import and Export Licences for Dual-Use Items and Technologies covers seven categories of medium and heavy rare earths — samarium, gadolinium, terbium, dysprosium, lutetium, scandium, and yttrium. Kyodo reported that these medium and heavy rare earths are extremely important for advanced weapons manufacturing; if they too come under restriction, the impact on Japanese enterprises will be major. This dependence exposes several core Japanese industries to risk. According to the calculations of Nomura Research Institute economist

Toshihiro Nagahama, if the rare-earth export controls last three months, Japan could suffer economic losses of about 660 billion yen. The automobile industry bears the brunt: the drive motors of EVs and hybrids depend on neodymium magnets; Japanese carmakers have suspended production of some models in the past due to rare-earth shortages, and substitute technologies are not yet commercialised^[9]. For years, Democrats and Republicans have warned of America's dependence on China for drug production. An analysis published on Wednesday shows how deep this dependence reaches at the earliest stage of the drug production process: nearly 700 American drugs use at least one chemical raw material produced only in China^[10]. After analysing Pentagon spending across nine key areas — aviation, maritime, C4I, mission support, nuclear, missiles and munitions, ground, missile defence, and space — Govini researchers conclude that the US defence supply chain is "extremely fragile," and that China, classified as an "adversary," holds the largest number of its tier-1 suppliers. America's dependence on Chinese suppliers is reportedly highest in missile defence, at 11.1%, and lowest in the nuclear field, at 7.8%, where 45% of suppliers are in the US. However, among foreign suppliers in the nuclear field, Chinese suppliers are the most numerous (534), up 45.5% from the previous year; by comparison, suppliers from American allies Canada and Britain number 405 and 366 respectively^[11].

Japan's industrial dependence on China is entirely the result of the rational choices of the big Japanese multinationals. As shown below^[12]:

Figure 3.1 Share of Vertical Intra-Industry Trade in Japan's Trade with nine East Asian Economies: Electrical Machinery Industry



Source: Authors' calculation based on Japan's trade statistics taken from http://www.customs.go.in/tokei/download/index_d01.htm 知路@最遥远的路

2. The Transnational Bourgeoisie and the Nation-State

The Forbes Global 2000 of 2025 — the world's 2,000 largest multinationals — had total revenue of \$52.9 trillion, 47.6% of the 2024 world GDP of \$111 trillion. Their total assets reached \$252 trillion, accounting for a large share of global assets^{[16][17]}.

This year marks the 23rd anniversary of the Forbes Global 2000 ranking, which ranks the world's largest listed companies by four metrics: sales, profits, assets, and market value. Despite geopolitical turmoil and the impact of Donald Trump's tariff policies, all four metrics hit record highs this year.

The 2,000 companies on the 2025 list had combined annual revenue of \$52.9 trillion, profits of \$4.9 trillion, assets of \$242.2 trillion, and market value of \$91.3 trillion.^[18]

Transnational capital controls the global value chains; the centre countries hold financial hegemony, military hegemony, high-skilled labour, and consumer markets; the peripheral countries hold labour and natural resources. The combination of transnational capital with the centre countries — mainly with their state apparatuses, helping them push policies favourable to profit maximisation across the globe — has existed since the very birth of capitalism. But the combination of transnational capital with the bourgeoisies of the peripheral countries (whether state-capitalist bureaucratic groups or national bourgeoisies dominated by private capital) is a new feature of this age. Transnational capital based in the centre has established an "alliance" with the peripheral bourgeoisies, making it possible for the peripheral countries to achieve rapid economic development by joining the global industrial chains. We discussed this in the first chapter. What needs to be pointed out here is that, as country after country completes its industrialisation, climbs the value chains, and begins to export capital, the ranks of the transnational bourgeoisie keep expanding. After the Second World War, the transnational bourgeoisie came first mainly from America, then Western Europe, Japan, South Korea; now the capitalists of China and even Vietnam are joining these ranks.

The transnational bourgeoisie has common interests — for example, it wants every country to reduce regulation, weaken labour organisations, cut taxes, open domestic markets, and privatise state assets. Within the transnational bourgeoisie, various capital groups form for various reasons — enterprise alliances, relations between enterprises and nation-states, and so on. Generally speaking, the newly joining transnational bourgeoisies always form a relatively fierce competitive relationship with the old, especially with the dominant transnational bourgeoisie. In international relations, this appears as the so-called suppression of rising semi-peripheral countries by the centre countries. This suppression can even develop to the point of war.

The relationship between the nation-state and the transnational bourgeoisie is also complex. The nation-state must serve the transnational bourgeoisie — especially its home-based transnational bourgeoisie — providing political and financial conditions for its capital export, as in the "Belt and Road" projects. However, the industrial transfer brought by capital export weakens the nation-state's industrial capacity. For instance, the transfer of the middle- and low-end links of American

manufacturing caused the decline of America's defence industry. Hence the nation-states still have to adopt various policies^{[19][20][21][22][23]}.

In the era of transnational production capitalism, the nation-state no longer possesses its former independence. The nation-state must recognise that it exists within a globalised market, operating within the global "civil society" composed of the transnational bourgeoisie and the proletariat it employs. If any nation-state tries, by political or military means, to force a retreat to the previous stage of the world-system, the transnational bourgeoisie will certainly protest through concrete action^{[24][25]}.

However, the transnational bourgeoisie after all still operates in a world of nation-states; it has not yet seized a transnational state power. The current regional political organisations such as the EU, though possessing some state characteristics like a central bank, have neither the power to tax nor an army, and cannot yet count as states in the true sense. And the global organisations — the UN, the IMF, the World Bank, the WTO — possess no state characteristics at all. Hence the transnational bourgeoisie must rely on the nation-states to carry out its functions across the globe.

First, the transnational bourgeoisie needs state power to protect private property rights. The capital in every country cannot be arbitrarily expropriated by the nation-states; even nationalisation requires corresponding compensation. China, for instance, has policies and legislation protecting foreign investment, and has reached agreements with other countries to guarantee investment security. In the Nexperia semiconductor affair, the Chinese government also used state power to counter Europe^[26].

Expropriation risk is one of the major risks of transnational investment. Particularly for our country, as a socialist state whose economic base is public ownership, how to reassure foreign investors about investing in China is a problem we must face and solve. On expropriation, Article 20 of the Foreign Investment Law provides: "The state does not expropriate foreign investment; in special circumstances, where expropriation is needed for the public interest, it shall be carried out in accordance with legal procedures and fair and reasonable compensation shall be given." This article in principle clarifies that foreign enterprises will not be expropriated, and that even expropriation in special circumstances should be fairly and reasonably compensated. In addition, whether the capital contributions, profits, capital gains, etc. of enterprises can be freely remitted abroad is a core concern of foreign investors. On this, Article 21 of the Foreign Investment Law provides: "The capital contributions, profits, capital gains, proceeds from disposal of assets, intellectual property licensing fees, and compensation or damages lawfully obtained by foreign investors in China may be freely remitted into or out of China in RMB or foreign exchange, in accordance with the law." The legislation protects the free flow of foreign investors' current-account items.^[27]

On the upgrading of bilateral investment treaties: as of July 2025, China has signed a total of 149 bilateral investment treaties with countries and regions, of which 109 BITs are currently in force. Besides advancing the early entry into force of suspended agreements, China also needs to start from drafting a model BIT text, focusing on investor protection, expropriation and compensation, and investment dispute settlement mechanisms.^[28]

However strong a single multinational company may be, it has no warships or tanks and cannot compare with a nation-state. Even a company as mighty as Apple (market value \$3.8 trillion), when it runs into a middle power like Indonesia (GDP \$1.4 trillion), must quickly admit its error and pay protection money.

According to Reuters, Indonesia's industry ministry said on Wednesday that the tech giant has proposed a \$100 million investment plan to build a factory in the country producing accessories and components. Earlier, the Indonesian government had banned the sale of the iPhone 16 in the country for failing to meet local-content requirements. Indonesia requires smartphones sold domestically to contain at least 40% locally made components, and has also banned the sale of other smartphones for similar reasons.^[29]

Not only middle powers like Indonesia — even a small African country like Niger (population 28 million, GDP under \$20 billion) dares to strike hard at a giant multinational like CNPC (market value near \$300 billion):

According to Reuters last week, the military government of the West African country Niger ordered three Chinese executives of local oil companies to leave the country within 48 hours. AFP reported that the three work for China National Petroleum Corporation, the West African Crude Oil Pipeline Company, and SORAZ. CNPC extracts oil in Niger; the West African Crude Oil Pipeline Company, a CNPC subsidiary, operates the crude pipeline; SORAZ is the refining company. Reuters quoted Oumarou on Wednesday (19 March): "We are not satisfied with the distribution of wealth between Niger and its partners." He revealed that Chinese employees in Niger earned an average monthly salary of \$8,678 last year, while Nigerien employees in the same positions earned only \$1,200. Foreign employees occupy the management positions; Nigeriens mostly hold the less visible operator or worker posts.^[30]

Niger's stated reason was that local wages were too low; in essence it is still the distribution of oil and gas revenue. Not only Niger — Burkina Faso^{[31][32]} and other Sahel countries have all seen the rise of so-called resource nationalism, whose aim is to make greater use of their own natural resources to develop their economies.

Everything in this world, from people to natural resources, fundamentally belongs to the sovereign states; the "ownership" of the multinational corporations is limited and can be adjusted by the

nation-states at any time. This makes transnational capital depend on strong nation-states. For example, after Trump tore up the Iran nuclear agreement in 2018, although Merkel urged European enterprises to keep doing business with Iran, in the face of American opposition, the executives of the big companies all said they had to comply with American law and withdraw from Iran.

To minimise the impact, Europe is actively lobbying Iran to stay in the agreement. According to Reuters, on the 10th, German Chancellor Merkel telephoned Iranian President Rouhani, saying Germany would continue to support the JCPOA as long as Iran continued to honour it. Earlier the same day, the French president also called Rouhani. According to the Wall Street Journal on the 9th, in 2016 Shell signed a contract to license its petrochemical technology for sale to Iran. According to Iran's IRNA in December 2016, Shell also signed exploration agreements with the National Iranian Oil Company for three oil and gas fields. But after the American withdrawal from the JCPOA was announced, these European companies began to evaluate their earlier investment plans, even considering the possibility that the new American sanctions would force them to leave Iran^[33].

Sovereign states can confront great powers, but multinational companies cannot — if they resist, they cannot do business globally. All this, of course, depends on the balance of forces.

Second, the multinationals need the nation-states to guarantee the security of the global trade network. Because transnational production has brought a surge in global trade, unimpeded trade routes have become the foundation of global production. If trade is interrupted, it is not merely a problem of unsold goods — production itself cannot continue. For instance, when Somali pirates plagued international trade years ago, the UN Security Council passed resolutions to fight piracy; not only the Western countries sent navies, China also dispatched a task force to join the operation^{[34][35][36]}. At the Davos forum, China held high the banner of free trade, winning deep recognition from transnational capital^{[37][38][39][40]}.

Third, transnational capital needs the nation-states to fight proletarian politics. Whether in its home country or in the countries where it invests, transnational capital needs state protection when facing proletarian resistance. All modern history proves to us that whether in India^{[41][42][43][44]} or elsewhere, state force is essential.

Finally, the multinationals need the power of the hegemonic nation-state to open the markets of various countries. Post-war history proves that America's various regime-change operations, besides fighting communism, served above all to open the markets of nation-states for the multinationals — letting the big companies enter each country, carry out financial looting, and take control of the host country's assets. In Iraq, in Venezuela, this is what America has been doing^[45].

So the nation-states cannot do without transnational capital, and transnational capital cannot do without the nation-states. There are alliances and struggles among the multinationals, and alliances

and struggles among the nation-states. This complex situation has provoked different theoretical readings in the broad left.

Scholars represented by Negri and Hardt hold that the "imperialism" of the nation-states has been replaced by "Empire." The era of imperialism is over; the "Empire" of "post-imperialism" is the new form of global rule:

Other theorists are unwilling to recognise the important shift in global power relations, because they believe the major capitalist nation-states have always dominated other countries and regions in imperialist fashion. From this perspective, the present tendency of the world toward Empire presents no fundamentally new phenomenon, but merely the self-perfection of imperialism. We should not underestimate these real, important continuities; however, we should also note this: whereas in the past there was competition and conflict among the imperialist powers, today, in many important respects, competition and conflict have been replaced by the idea of a single power that controls and determines them all, gives them a uniform structure, and treats them in accordance with a universal, postcolonial and post-imperialist conception of right. This is the point of departure of our study of Empire: without a doubt a new conception of power, or rather a new depiction of authority — a new mode of production of norms, legal instruments, and coercive institutions that protect contracts and eliminate conflicts^[46].

Robinson, meanwhile, points out that the globalisation of production is not only transforming the nation-states but giving birth to the formation of a transnational state:

To repeat: the transnational state apparatus is an emerging network that includes transformed and externally integrated nation-states and supranational economic and political organisations, but it has not yet taken the form of a centralised institutional structure. The rise of the transnational state makes the restructuring of each nation-state inevitable — hence I call the states on each national territory nation-states — and at the same time encompasses the emergence of genuinely supranational economic and political institutions. These two processes — the transformation of the nation-states and the rise of supranational institutions — do not proceed separately or to the exclusion of each other. In fact, they are two dimensions of the transnationalisation of the state. My central argument is that in the age of globalisation the nation-state has not "withered"; its functions are being transformed, and it is becoming an organic component of a larger transnational state^[47].

Ellen Wood expressed disagreement with the two views above (especially Negri and Hardt's). She held that in the age of economic globalisation, the nation-state remains the fundamental state form. Transnational capital needs the nation-states to help organise global production; without the nation-states, even globalisation itself could not be maintained:

We are constantly told nowadays that globalisation is undermining the nation-state, and we hear a great deal about "global governance." It seems to be simply a matter of the economic base and the

superstructure in a simple mechanical relation: if the global economy does not mean a global state, it must mean global governance. Of course, these theories recognise that lagging political forms cannot keep up with the global economy. This is not only asserted by traditional globalisation theorists; it is also the root of the "Empire" theory of Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, which rests on the premise that the expansion of global capital implies the development of a new kind of sovereignty... Capital is by no means less dependent on territorial states than it was before. In some respects it is more dependent; the world is more than ever a world of nation-states. To be sure, the nation-states must respond to the demands of global capital. Certain social, legal, and administrative principles have been internationalised to facilitate the cross-border movement of capital. Certain international organisations operate in accordance with the demands of global capital. But that does not mean the "internationalisation" of the state. The main instruments of global governance remain the nation-states. We live in a world of uneven development. Globalisation is not an integrated global economy; this is why the global economy coexists with a fragmented system of localised states. Global capital benefits from globalisation, but it cannot organise globalisation. Some researchers hold that global companies cannot even organise their own international operations on their own, let alone the global economy. In any case, they need the nation-states to organise the world for them. The more globalised the economy, the more the circuits of the economy need coordination by states and between states. For global capital, the state — not international organisations like the IMF and the WTO — is indispensable^[48].

The three views above were all published in the early 2000s, when globalisation was booming worldwide and America, leading all countries, held high the banner of neoliberalism to sweep away every obstacle to globalisation. By the 2020s, the nation-state ruled by the Trump group — America — is walking the road of de-globalisation. We can now evaluate these views more objectively.

First, on the state apparatus, Ellen Wood's view must be acknowledged as closer to reality. Faced with the Trump group's destruction of the global economic order, international organisations such as the WTO are paralysed and utterly powerless to restrain it; in the end, it is still the nation-states that have to build bilateral or multilateral regional free-trade arrangements.

However, Ellen Wood imagines the transnational bourgeoisie as too passive, thinking it cannot organise international production without the nation-states. But the facts of recent years show that the multinationals have independent and proactive strategies for dealing with conflicts among nation-states^[49]. One should not underestimate global capital's capacity for "re-globalisation"; some advocate that China should adopt "unilateral opening" to attract transnational capital^[50].

In short, the nation-state remains the only form of state apparatus, but what the nation-state rules is merely a part of the global market. The multinationals operate across the globe, within the world market, not fully controlled by any single nation-state. There are relations of cooperation and struggle between nation-states and multinationals. The nation-states need the multinationals when

they struggle with one another; and the multinationals need the nation-states when they struggle with one another.

Economic globalisation does demand the appearance of a world government, but a unified global state has both advantages and disadvantages for the bourgeoisie. The current degree of globalisation benefits the bourgeoisie on balance, because if a world government appeared, global taxation and labour protection would inevitably be put on the agenda — which the bourgeoisie does not want to see. But when the proletariat, breaking through the divisions of the nation-states, unites and moves toward socialist reform or revolution, the bourgeoisie of a single country will hardly withstand the attack of an organised transnational proletariat; only then may the transnational bourgeoisie propose to unite the nation-states and form a world government to maintain the capitalist order.

3. The Hegemonic State and Multipolarity

In the capitalist world-system, although there have been hegemonic states such as Holland and Britain, never before has a single country held sole dominance for so long as America did after the Second World War. After the Industrial Revolution, Britain enjoyed sole dominance for a time, but that dominance was more economic than military. As the other countries completed their industrial revolutions in turn, Britain lost even its industrial supremacy, and was soon left with only naval and financial hegemony, having to maintain its global position through a web of alliances. America is different: from 1945 to about 2010, it was the unquestioned hegemon of the capitalist world. In economics, industry, science and technology, finance, the military, and even ideological influence, America held overwhelming superiority. Economic globalisation not only failed to change this structure but helped America split and defeat the socialist camp. This led people to wonder: does the age of economic globalisation require a nation-state hegemon to perform the functions of a world government?

In my articles "How Many Poles in a Multipolar World? A Look Ahead to 2050" and "The Logic of War and Its Prospects," I discussed multipolarity. In summary, in the current capitalist world-system, state power in the world market is multipolar; the fundamental reasons can be reduced to two:

First, with the rise of the bourgeoisies of the vast colonial and semi-colonial regions, nationalism developed across the broad expanses of Asia, Africa, and Latin America, and national independence was inevitably won. These independent small and medium countries can no longer be arbitrarily politically dominated by a hegemonic power. Great powers can oppress small and medium countries, but truly restoring the traditional colonies and semi-colonies, engaging in land annexation, is nearly impossible. The resistance of the people makes such rule very expensive. It has been proved that even a power as strong as Russia found it very hard to annex eastern Ukraine, where ethnic Russians

predominate — let alone the western regions where Ukrainians dominate. America blockades Venezuela and Iran but dares not send troops to occupy them — even the craziest ruling class must bow before reality.

Second, since the great powers cannot directly annex small and medium countries to increase their population and resources, the long-run strength of a state is determined by the population size of the nation-state itself. The global population will ultimately be around 9-something billion, of which two countries have over a billion: China and India. The countries with populations between 200 million and a billion are the United States, Indonesia, Pakistan, Nigeria, and Brazil. More than ten countries have populations between 100 and 200 million. All of these have the potential to become regional or world powers. And there is a whole host of countries with tens of millions — not enough to contend for hegemony, but sufficient for self-defence (Ukraine, Venezuela). If any country seeks hegemony, the others can unite against it, and the combined strength of the opponents will far exceed the would-be hegemon. Hence multipolarity and multilateralism must be the irreversible great trend of the future world. On this point, my article "How Many Poles in a Multipolar World?" offers some analysis of the world-level poles of the future multipolar world.

If multipolarity is the trend, why does America, whose industrial output and trade share are already far below China's, still use its hegemony to bully other countries? Contrary to what most people think, America's hegemony rests not on the US military but on the dollar. We often hear of "dollar hegemony," but what does dollar hegemony actually mean?

We know that the capitalist economy cannot function without money; money is the soul of the capitalist economy. Once capitalist production became globalised production, the significance of world money changed from earlier stages. When production was still mainly organised within one country, world money mainly served as an intermediary of international trade, used to balance trade. Marx gave a classic formulation in *Capital*:

When money leaves the domestic sphere of circulation, it strips off the local garbs of price standard, coin, subsidiary coin, and value symbol, which it acquired there, and returns to its original form of bullion. In world trade, commodities unfold their value universally. Hence here their independent value-form confronts them as world money. It is only in the world market that money functions to the full extent as the commodity whose natural form is also the directly social form of realisation of abstract human labour. Its mode of existence becomes adequate to its concept. As the universal means of payment, the universal means of purchase, and the absolutely social materialisation of universal wealth, world money performs its functions. Its most important function is as a means of payment in balancing international trade balances. Hence the slogan of the mercantile system — the trade balance! Gold and silver serve as international means of purchase chiefly when the normal equilibrium of the material exchange between nations is suddenly disturbed. Finally, they function as the absolutely social materialisation of wealth wherever wealth is to be transferred from one country to another

without purchase or payment, and the state of the commodity market, or the purpose itself, does not permit the transfer in commodity form. — Marx, Capital, Volume I

In Marx's day, gold and silver performed the function of international payment; today, that function is performed by the dollar. Hence, although the dollar's share in the foreign-exchange reserves of the central banks has fallen considerably, it remains far above all other currencies^[51].

In essence, whether dollars, renminbi, or yen, the actual paper currency printed is very little; most is only numbers on bank ledgers — apart from the deposit figures created by bank lending, the ultimate monetary records sit in the central banks' ledgers. For global trade to be settled in renminbi or a new currency would merely move the bookkeeping from computers in the American banking system to computers in Chinese or European banks — it looks indeed very simple.

China is currently the largest trading partner of most countries in the world, with a surplus of over a trillion dollars. America, by contrast, has long run a deficit of over a trillion dollars. Countries exchange their products for the dollar, which itself has no value. As Lula asked, why can't the world's major countries simply replace the dollar?

Because in the era of globalised production, the dollar is used not only for trade settlement but also to support the self-expansion of capital in the globalised age. Enterprises investing need currency to buy inputs (machinery, components, etc.) on the international market; this function cannot be performed by the national currency alone, because large-scale financing in the national currency for imports would exhaust the foreign exchange. This creates a demand for dollar credit expansion. The more the international market develops, the greater this demand. In the ledgers of banking systems outside America, large quantities of dollar records have been accumulated through loans, bonds, and other instruments. This is the so-called "Eurodollar." The Eurodollar is not only dollars in European banks, but also dollars held in the banks of Hong Kong, Singapore, Dubai, and elsewhere — hence also called offshore dollars. Many scholars point out that the Eurodollar, which arose and developed spontaneously in the global market, is the true foundation of dollar hegemony. An article by a Chinese scholar puts it clearly:

The Eurodollar is a dollar deposit circulating outside the United States, existing in the form of numbers on bank ledgers rather than physical currency. This ledger-money system, through the global banking network, achieves efficient capital flows and has become the core pillar of the modern globalised economy. The operation of the Eurodollar system depends on complex financial infrastructure, including monetary utilities (such as CHIPS and CLS) and financial market platforms (such as the ICE and the CME). These institutions integrate millions of ledgers worldwide, ensuring the efficiency of capital flows. However, this bank-dominated system requires heavy investment and maintenance, and its operation takes place entirely within the international banking network. Despite these challenges, the Eurodollar system remains the core of the global reserve currency even after

nearly two decades. This shows its irreplaceability in global finance. Many people wrongly believe that countries can easily switch to other currencies, but replacing the Eurodollar would require building an equally efficient global intermediary currency system, which is extremely challenging under current technological conditions.^[52]

Because offshore dollars are based on the American banking system and must ultimately be cleared in America, the US government occupies a special position in the global financial system. America's army would find it very hard to conquer even a middle power, but through financial sanctions it can entirely mire a regional power in distress. Moreover, the dollar's status as an international currency lets American consumers keep importing goods from abroad with their own currency. As long as the dollar remains the international currency, and as long as the trade deficit stays within the international market's demand for dollars, a chronic trade deficit causes no exchange-rate problem. Hence America became the world's largest importer, and Trump can use the tariff club to make countries submit. Making the countries that sell to you surrender, with dollars you "print" yourself, seems absurd — yet it reflects the essence of capitalist production as commodity production: production is for value, not use value. And the general bearer of value is not the commodity but money. In the international market, this money is the dollar. In the capitalists' eyes, the dollars on bank ledgers are wealth, while the goods piling up in warehouses are useless — this absurd phenomenon Marx called "commodity fetishism."

Of course, the world does not stand still. The astonishing fact that money is nothing but numbers recorded in bank computers also highlights the importance of credit, confidence, and trust. The capitalist economy operates on trust in the banking system. The Trump administration is squandering the long-accumulated trust in the dollar. Now scholars everywhere are discussing how to "de-dollarise," how to replace the dollar with a new monetary system.

In short, dollar hegemony exists. For America, this hegemony is like an inexhaustible gold mine. America naturally benefits from this hegemony (Chinese scholars estimate that America's annual "broad seigniorage" income from dollar hegemony reaches 1%, even 2%, of US GDP^{[53][54]}).

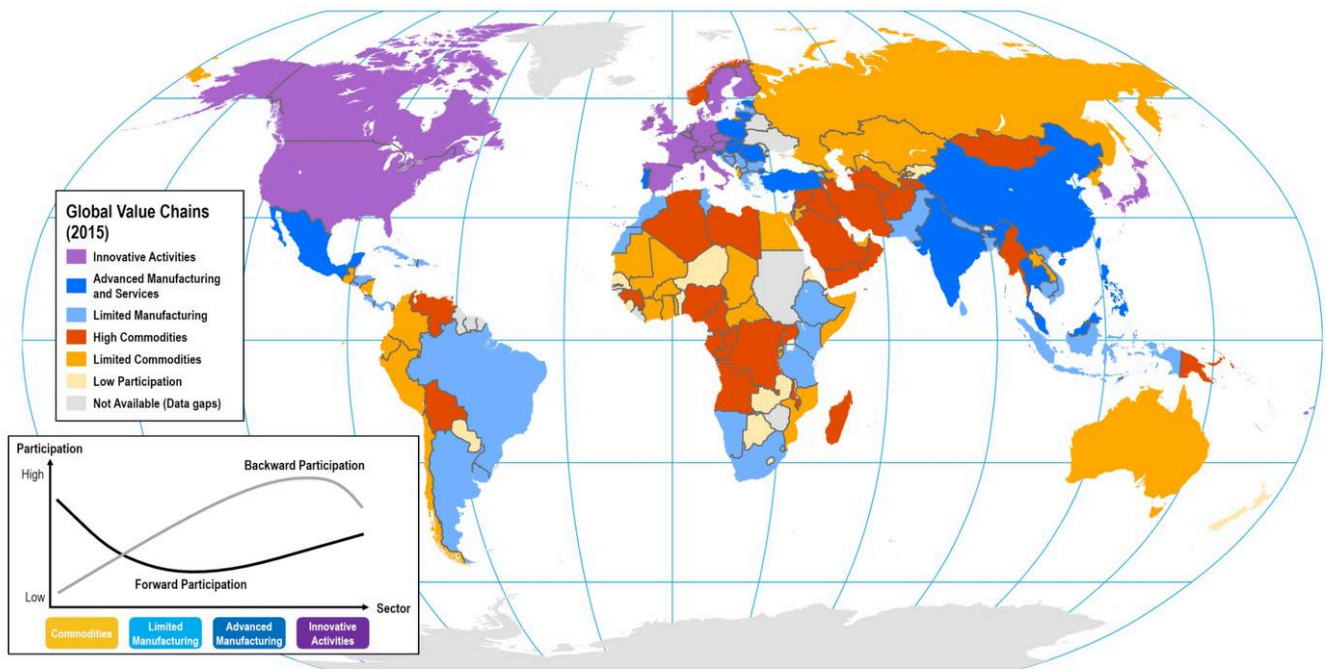
As for whether the internationalisation of the renminbi will go that far, it depends on various factors, including the calculations of the rulers. After all, enjoying the benefits of an international currency means bearing the corresponding risks and responsibilities.

4. Centre-Periphery and Unequal Exchange

What is the structure of the current world-system?

We know that the level of economic development of every country today depends on its position in the global value chains.

The chart below shows the position of the world's countries in the global value chains in 2015^[55]:



The Configuration of Global Value Chains

Source: World Bank (2020) *World Development Report 2020: Trading for Development in the Age of Global Value Chains*, Washington: World Bank.

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More than ten years later, the overall configuration of our world remains basically what the chart shows — the only difference being that China is shifting from an advanced manufacturing country toward "innovative activities," i.e. the innovative or centre countries. In my article "Can the World Make Room for a Developed China?" I analysed whether China's overall rise to developed-country status is compatible with the structure of the current world-system. The conclusion was that in 2024 China's rise would significantly impact the centre countries, but with the global expansion and accumulation of capital, by 2040 the global centre-periphery structure would be basically close to what it was in 2010.

Why are the workers of the developed countries paid so much? Are the developed countries exploiting the others? Is there unequal exchange in the trade between centre and periphery? Are all the workers of the centre countries worker aristocrats?

In my answer "Can China break through the threshold of developed countries in the next ten years?" I analysed this question:

According to the statistics of the relevant institutions, the average monthly income of Chinese university graduates in 2024 was 6,199 yuan^{[56][57][58]}. Three years after graduation, the average wage of university graduates has already reached about 80% of Italy's average net wage. As China's industry merges with the industries of the former developed countries, and forms upstream-downstream relations with the vast rapidly industrialising South, China's internal industrial structure will also become one dominated by high-skilled labour. This change will be completed within the next 10–15 years. As long as the real wages of Chinese workers can keep a low growth of 2%–3% a year over the next 15 years, the average wage level of Chinese workers will converge with Europe's.

The developed countries are developed because the share of highly educated labourers among them is high, and the reduced supply of blue-collar workers has narrowed the difference between physical and mental labour, so the average income of workers is higher. For the highly educated labourers of the semi-peripheral countries that have completed industrialisation (China, Brazil, etc.), the real purchasing power of their incomes is not much lower than that of their counterparts in the developed countries.

Why are white-collar wages generally higher than blue-collar? White-collar workers generally need higher education, so white-collar labour is in essence complex labour. By the rough estimate that four years of university cost about four years of total savings, plus four years of opportunity cost, university costs the equivalent of eight years of income. With a working life of 40 years, one must earn an extra 20% of wages per year ($8/40$) for it to pay off. For a bachelor's degree, counting the investment in examinations from childhood, the premium must exceed 50%. If income is below this level, university loses its attraction. The chart below is from a paper by Japanese scholars^[59]:

College Wage Premium in Japan

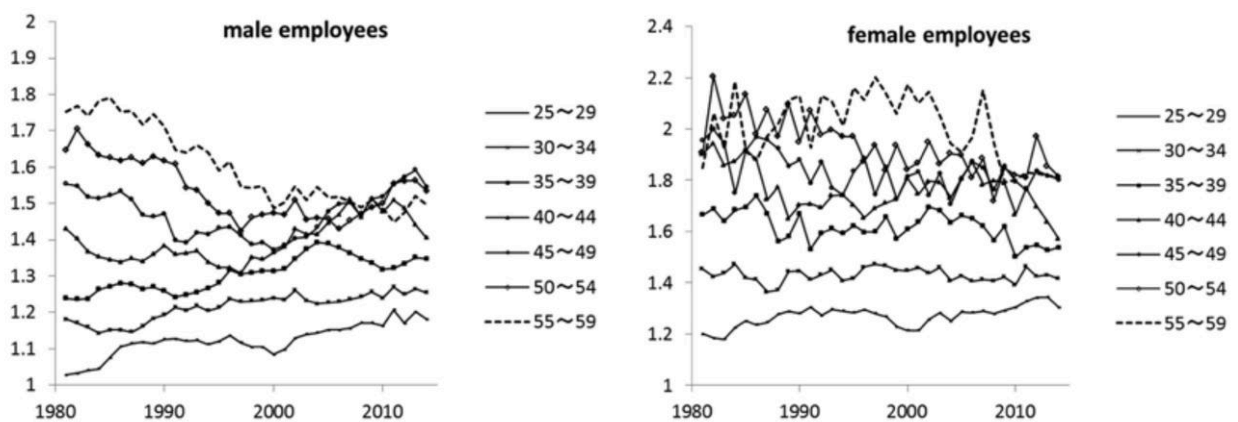


Figure 3 College wage premium: by age group

Source: Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, Basic Survey on Wage Structure, author's calculations

Between similar countries in similar positions, the wage differences of equally educated labourers are largely determined by supply and demand. If in the centre countries the supply of highly educated labourers exceeds demand while the supply of physical labourers falls short of demand, the income of physical labourers may exceed that of mental labourers. A paper by Japanese scholars^[60]:

Why has wage inequality in Japan remained unchanged over the past decades while inequality in the US has continued to worsen? This study points to the difference in the trends of the college wage premium between the two countries as the direct cause, and evaluates the importance of supply factors in determining the college wage premium. Between 1986 and 2008, the wage gap between Japanese university graduates and high-school graduates declined slightly from 0.35 to 0.34 log points, while in the US it rose from 0.43 to 0.65 log points. During this period, the number of Japanese university graduates grew twice as fast as America's. Estimating labour demand by education and simulating with counterfactual supply trends, the results show that the faster growth of Japanese university graduates explains about 60% of the difference in wage-gap trends between the two countries. The difference in post-war fertility trends largely explains the difference in the growth rates of university graduate supply.

The semi-peripheral countries demand more physical than mental workers; the centre countries the reverse. If the supply of university graduates in the semi-periphery is too large, the income of university graduates depreciates rapidly. Similarly, if the supply of physical labourers in the centre is too great, their income also falls. This is why the developed countries control the educational level of immigrants. The global supply of physical labourers is huge, and the wage gap between centre and periphery physical workers is large; if immigration were opened, the wages of the centre's physical workers would fall rapidly with the huge supply. For mental labourers the reverse: the centre's supply exceeds the periphery's, and the wage gap for mental labourers between periphery and centre is not so great, so even with open immigration, the supply would not be too large. Of course, the rapid spread of higher education in the periphery and semi-periphery over the last one or two decades is changing this situation.

If the wages of similar workers in different countries are roughly the same, and the differences are determined by supply and demand, then does unequal exchange exist between centre and periphery? And if it exists, what role does it play?

On this question, the left-wing theoretical world is sharply divided.

According to the world-systems view, there is a structural unequal exchange between centre and periphery. This unequal exchange comes from the difference in organic composition of capital between centre and periphery, and the wage differences caused by the low labour prices of the periphery:

Against the background of the new phenomena of the 1970s — "industrial transfer" and multinational activity — Emmanuel, starting from the reality of wage differences between countries and the worsening terms of trade of the Third World countries, used Marx's framework of prices of production to explain the development gap between countries, sparking a controversy over the categories of the contemporary world-market theory. Emmanuel pointed out that competition of capital under capitalism necessarily leads to unequal exchange. The difference in organic composition of capital between countries leads to unequal exchange in the broad sense, and the difference in wage rates between countries leads to unequal exchange in the narrow sense. This is the fundamental reason for the development gap between developing and developed countries. The attention to wage differences constitutes the core of Emmanuel's theory, but his analysis rests on complete division of labour and holds only under the assumption of uniform technology; the rate of surplus value is in fact the true factor affecting the deviation between international value and international prices of production. At the same time, he attributes the development gap entirely to exogenous wage differences, subordinating all other factors that determine the formation of world market prices and the terms of exchange, without considering that wage differences are themselves the result of unequal exchange, affected by the changing environment of the world market. Moreover, this mechanism of value transfer may not be sufficient to constitute an obstacle to the development of the Third World^[61].

But some scholars hold that commodity exchange takes place according to the socially necessary labour time of the world market, not that of a single country; because the countries with low organic composition have low labour productivity, their commodities contain less socially necessary labour time than the national average. This is not unequal exchange but precisely exchange of equivalents:

German scholars such as Busch point out that countries with different levels of productive forces differ in the realisation of value in international trade, causing economic gaps — but this is the result of exchange of equivalents according to international value, and does not constitute unequal exchange at the international level. National value cannot serve as the basis of world-market trade; this analysis of value transfer violates the law of international value, while unequal exchange is the result of deviation from the law of international value — the pricing power of monopoly capital leads to unequal exchange^[62].

However, with the rise of the global value chains, multinationals have adopted vertical integration to organise production globally, and commodity exchange takes place mainly between the lead firms and their subcontractors — does unequal exchange exist in this exchange?

In the paper "Global value chains and unequal exchange: Market power and monopoly power," American scholars, on the basis of a simple model, conclude that unequal exchange exists in global value chain trade. This unequal exchange comes mainly from the lead firms' brands and technological or design patents, and from competition among suppliers:

We re-examine the assumptions of unequal exchange and deteriorating terms of trade, placing them in the concrete context of developing countries' dependence on integration into global value chains to access developed-country markets. We use a simplified two-country, two-commodity classical Marxist trade model. There are two sources of asymmetry: first, competition among suppliers drives down the prices of final products, producing market power; second, the lead firms' control and ownership of intangible assets, including brands and designs, produces monopoly power^[63].

In plain terms, because brands and patents give the lead firms a monopoly position, these big firms can obtain monopoly profits — Apple is the typical example. In addition, because the suppliers are highly substitutable, there is fierce competition among them — not only within a country, but among the peripheral countries too — and this competition also presses prices down. But it must be pointed out that the gains of this unequal exchange are distributed more among senior managers and shareholders; they do not necessarily benefit the employees of the lead firms. How much the workers get depends in the long run on the supply and demand of the labour market, and in the short run on the workers' struggle. It should also be considered that if the workers take too large a share of the monopoly profits, the enterprise can equally raise its profit rate by relocating to another country.

In summary, the differences among the centre, periphery, and semi-periphery are essentially the expression of the different positions of the enterprises of different countries on the global value chains. The unequal exchange between centre and periphery is essentially a question of profit distribution between the lead firms and their subcontracting suppliers. Since the lead firms are concentrated in the centre countries (see the distribution of the Global 500), this unequal exchange among enterprises appears as unequal exchange between centre and periphery. The industries of the centre countries demand more white-collar workers, while the industries of the semi-periphery and periphery demand more physical workers. Because white-collar labour is complex labour, its wages are 20%–50% higher than physical labour. The differences in the treatment of the working classes of different countries depend in the short run on the bargaining power of the working class, and in the long run on the supply and demand of labour. In countries just entering the centre, because the supply of university graduates is small, white-collar wages are higher than the real value of their labour power; but as the supply of graduates grows, white-collar wages gradually approach their real level. In the long run, the labour supply of the centre is on a declining trend; but if immigration is taken into account, the situation becomes more complex. On when China will become a developed country, see my answer: "Can China break through the threshold of developed countries in the next ten years?"

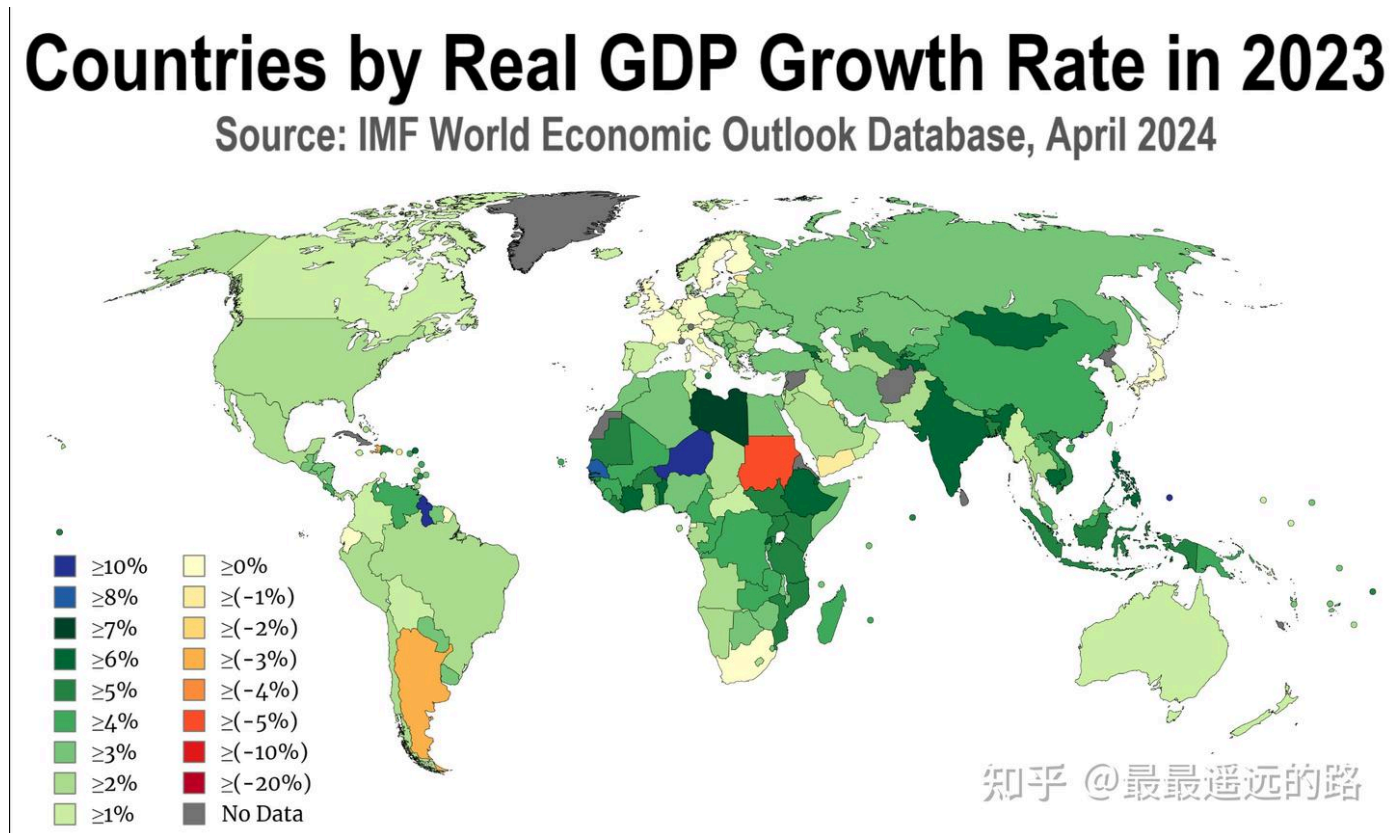
5. The Endpoint of the Global Expansion of Capital

Since America and Europe fell into long-term economic stagnation after the 2008 financial crisis, with severe social polarisation — especially after Trump took office — many American leftists have

been discussing that global capitalism, having fallen into over-accumulation, can no longer continue to develop and has entered a period of crisis. The expansion of the capitalist world-system has reached its limit.

Is that really so?

The chart below^[64]:



Therefore, capital accumulation in the capitalist world-system is still proceeding — only it no longer takes place in the centre countries but in the periphery. The economic development of the centre countries has fallen into stagnation; if no measures are taken to change the labour-capital relations, the inherent tendency of capitalism toward proletarian impoverishment will drive the class contradictions to sharpen rapidly, and the sharpening of class contradictions will necessarily appear politically — both the socialist left and the fascist right are expressions of this development of class contradictions. But in the vast periphery, the entry of foreign capital and the rapid accumulation of domestic capital appear as large-scale infrastructure investment, the substantial increase of output of basic industrial goods such as electricity, steel, and cement, an unprecedented process of urbanisation — in the final analysis, a rapid rise in the level of productive forces and an improvement in the actual living standards of the workers. On this, see my other answer: "How Do You See the Domestic 'Base'?"

If current capital accumulation has not fallen into stagnation, will it one day meet a bottleneck? And if so, when?

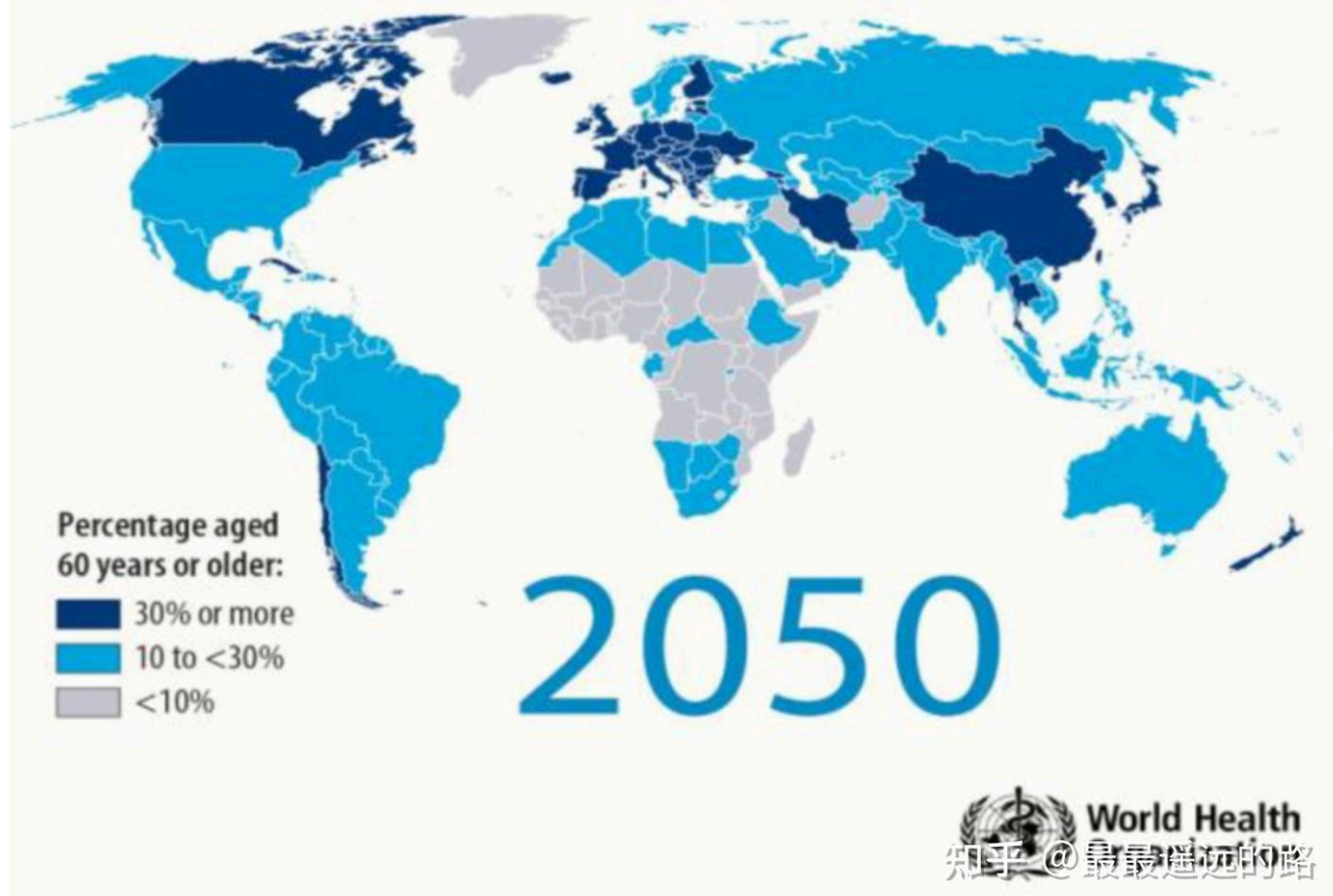
The capital accumulation promoted by the transnational bourgeoisie had its centre in China from the 1990s to the 2010s. With the contraction of China's total labour force, the centre of accumulation has moved to South Asia and Southeast Asia, represented by India, Indonesia, Vietnam, and Bangladesh.

At the current rate of development, Vietnam and India will complete their industrialisation within 20–25 years. Indonesia and Bangladesh may be slower, but they will basically complete industrialisation in the 2050s. On Vietnam's level of development, see my answer: "Why Do Some People Think Vietnam Can Rise?" On India, see: "Will India Develop into an Industrialised Country in the Foreseeable Future?"

Among the Middle Eastern countries, the GCC states are investing oil revenue in industry; their basic industrial output has already reached the level of industrial countries. Egypt, with its large population, has also entered the track of industrialisation, expected to complete it in the 2050s; see my answer: "How Should We View the Fall of Egypt's Population Growth Rate to 1.4%?"

By the 2050s, the surplus labour of all Asia and North Africa will have basically been absorbed into capitalist production. Only sub-Saharan Africa will still have large amounts of rural labour available for capital to absorb. Since the other regions will have fallen into ageing to varying degrees after the 2050s (see below^[65]):

Populations are getting older



As the chart shows, by 2050, besides Europe and East Asia falling into deep ageing, Africa and the rest of Asia will also enter varying degrees of ageing, and labour will gradually become scarce. Black Africa will become the main source of migrants.

The table below compiles, from my article "Can the World Make Room for a Developed China?", the projections of the labour-population shares of the countries in different positions of the world-system in 2050. It can be seen that the countries that have completed industrialisation and can export capital have a total labour force of 2.77 billion. And by various statistics, by 2050 sub-Saharan Africa's working-age population will increase by more than 600 million^{[66][67]}. Since the total fertility rate is falling faster than expected, the global population peak may well arrive even earlier.

类别	国家/地区	劳动年龄人口(百万)	农业人口比重	非农劳动年龄人口(百万)
发达国家	美国（UN预测值）	231	2%	226
	欧盟（相比2010年代下降5000万）	240	4%	237
	英国（按照2040年预测值）	47	1%	47
	日本	57	3%	48
	韩国	24	5%	26
	加拿大	27	2%	24
	澳大利亚	20	2%	19
	新西兰	3	6%	3
	新加坡	5	0%	5
	中国台湾	13	5%	12
	中国香港	5	0%	5
	以色列	6	1%	6
	瑞士	6	2%	6
	中国大陆（取决于2025年到2035年之间的出生人口，预测值从7亿到7.7亿均存在，取高值7.7亿）	770	4%	739
	总和			1403
寻求升级的主要国家	印度	1134.5	25.70%	843
	越南（当前26.5%，按当前趋势推测）	69	15%	59
	墨西哥（按当前趋势推测）	98	5%	93
	土耳其	57	10%	51
	伊朗（当前15%）	64	10%	58
	沙特（当前6%）	34	5%	32
	马来西亚（当前10%）	30	5%	29
	巴西（当前9%）	136	5%	129
	俄罗斯（当前18%）	82	10%	74
	总和			1368
全球	全球（UN预测人口，农业就业占比基于2040年取值和减少趋势取10%）	6110	10%	5499
	发达国家占全球比例			23.50%
	冲击发达国家占全球比例			24.80%

The essence of capital accumulation is the accumulation of wage labour; the current world-system depends on constantly absorbing the labourers of the peripheral regions, still in pre-capitalist relations of production, into capitalist production. When this source of the industrial reserve army dries up, the current world-system will fall into a structural predicament. The intensification of social contradictions seen in Europe and America will appear on a global scale. This time is around 2065 — forty years from now.

6. The Formation of a Transnational Proletariat?

Marx's famous statement in the Communist Manifesto: "The bourgeoisie, by the rapid improvement of all instruments of production, by the immensely facilitated means of communication, draws all, even the most barbarian, nations into civilisation... The weapons with which the bourgeoisie felled feudalism to the ground are now turned against the bourgeoisie itself. But not only has the bourgeoisie forged the weapons that bring death to itself; it has also called into existence the men who are to wield those weapons — the modern working class, the proletarians. In proportion as the bourgeoisie, i.e., capital, is developed, in the same proportion is the proletariat, the modern working class, developed." This has been proved by the history of the second stage of the capitalist world-system. In the third stage of the capitalist world-system, where the transnational bourgeoisie is fully developed, should a transnational proletariat develop in the same degree?

If we speak of a class in itself, the wage labourers already drawn into transnational capitalist production are already a transnational proletariat. The existence of this class is already a fact. But if we mean a class for itself, then this class must have its own class consciousness and its own organisation. In that sense, the transnational proletariat has not yet formed.

In fact, not only has the transnational proletariat not yet appeared as an organised, conscious class; the fragmentation caused by transnational production has thrown the existing national proletariats into political difficulties. In "Capitalism, Globalisation and the Age of Transition," published in 1996, Sven Langdon wrote:

The entire industrial working class is decomposed, deskilled (rendered obsolete by the development of technology), and then recomposed in the production process into two parts: highly skilled core workers and unskilled or semi-skilled "peripheral" workers. The factory that once housed thousands of workers is no longer fixed in one time and place, but extends around the world in the form of global production lines. Formerly capitalism had to rely on importing foreign labour; now capitalism can carry its factory to any part of the world where there is an abundant supply of cheap and easily controlled labour. The result: the organisations of the working class are fragmented or entirely destroyed; the working-class movement completely loses its fighting capacity. This eliminates the tension between capital and labour — the tension that once produced not only social reform (factory laws, education laws, public health laws) but also the bourgeois freedoms of speech, assembly, association, and universal suffrage, as well as the values and norms of social and human solidarity... This information society is managed by a group of "knowledge workers," who have become the collaborators of power.

Today, after globalisation has developed for decades, we all feel Sven Langdon was absolutely right — hasn't the working class of the developed countries been disintegrated precisely by this industrial transfer? But in the 1990s, America's industrial transfer was still under way and the country still had a good deal of manufacturing, so Langdon's claim was hard for the left of the time — especially the Marxists — to accept. For if his claim held, the workers' movements of Europe and America would sink into historical decline, even face destruction. Hence Ellen Wood responded to Langdon, pointing out that America's foreign investment mainly served local markets and that American manufacturing had not moved away. That is, Wood still held that the transnational production of the time was merely a replication of the mode of production of the second stage of the capitalist world-system in other countries — the globalisation of the relations of production, not of the mode of production:

No one, I believe, would deny that, as capitalism has become more international over the past twenty years, production has become more internationalised. But let us look at the facts: of the world's industrial output, foreign affiliates of multinationals account for 15%, and the remaining 85% is produced by national companies in a single region. It is true that finance capital can move abroad freely through electronic means, but industrial capital is not equally mobile, and its mobility does not

clearly correspond to Langdon's picture. For example, in 1993, 78.9% of American manufacturing foreign direct investment went to other advanced capitalist countries — Canada, Europe, Australia, Japan. Of course it also invested in the cheap, unskilled, unregulated labour of the Third World. I do not mean to underestimate the importance of this trend, but such choices naturally followed the logic of capitalist exploitation from the start. There may be evidence that this trend has accelerated recently, but there are also signs that it can move forward or retreat depending on economic conditions. And there is a kind of investment that cannot even fit into the "globalisation" model. For example, the traditional model assumes that investment in cheaper, less regulated labour markets must directly displace domestic production. But most of the goods America produces with this cheap labour are sold in that country, not shipped back to America; and the vast majority of American manufacturing production takes place in America — the proportion has expanded, not shrunk, compared with the past decades: domestic manufacturing production has increased fivefold since 1950.

History has shown that in this debate, Langdon was right and Ellen Wood was wrong. Now not only do Europe, America, Japan, and Korea not produce clothing, shoes, and socks — even Chinese enterprises have begun to relocate to Cambodia and other countries, and Cambodia-made Li-Ning sportswear has appeared in Chinese shopping malls. Ellen Wood did not realise that the industrial reserve army of the European and American proletariats was exhausted, that capital accumulation had hit a bottleneck, and that this contradiction could not be solved without exporting capital. And if capital is exported, the nation-states of the centre cannot benefit from this industrial transfer; they must change their industrial structure and shift wholesale to the high end of the industrial chains, maintaining the centre's labour and technological advantages.

The effect of industrial outsourcing on working-class organisation is direct. The paper "Offshoring and the Decline of Unions"^[68]:

Using an employer-employee dataset covering all firms and workers over the past two decades, this paper explores the role of globalisation in the decline of unionisation rates. The dataset allows us to identify how firm-level offshoring changes affect individual workers' union membership decisions, controlling for various potential confounders. The results show that exogenous offshoring growth reduces unionisation rates. Specifically, offshoring can explain about a quarter of the decline in unionisation over the past two decades. This finding is not driven merely by the changes in industry, firm, worker, or occupation composition caused by offshoring. Rather, even with employer-employee matching, our results show that the threat of offshoring reduces workers' likelihood of joining or staying in unions, pointing to a bargaining-power explanation. As expected, the effect is stronger in occupations with higher offshoring exposure and in more flexible wage-setting systems. Two further results confirm that the negative relationship is due to offshoring reducing union bargaining power. First, we find that the union wage premium exists and has been declining over time, and is lower in firms where offshoring threatens jobs. Second, a rent-sharing model shows that union workers in offshoring firms obtain a relatively smaller share of rents. Overall, the empirical evidence of this paper

shows that offshoring reduces union bargaining power, erodes the wages and benefits of union members, and thereby reduces unionisation rates.

Trade-union organisation is the key link in the working class's passage from a class in itself to a class for itself.

Marx, in *Wages, Price and Profit*, stated clearly that the trade unions are necessary for the working class's struggle. From the standpoint of economic struggle, without unions the living standards of the working class can hardly be raised. The stagnation of American workers' real wages over the last thirty years (see: "A Family of Four, One Wage Earner, a House and a Car — Did American Workers Really Have Such Good Days?") is directly connected with the decline of the American union movement.

As long as society is divided into two opposing classes — on one side the capitalists, the monopolists of all the means of production, land, raw materials, and machinery; on the other the labourers, robbed of all ownership of the means of production, owning nothing but their labour power — as long as this social organisation exists, the law of wages remains omnipotent, and forges anew every day the chains that make the worker the slave of the product he himself has made but which the capitalist monopolises. The English trade unions have been fighting this law for nearly sixty years — and with what result? Have they freed the working class from the slavery of capital — the product of the working class's own hands? Have they raised even a part of the working class above the position of wage slaves, making them owners of their own means of production — the raw materials, tools, and machinery they need in production — and hence owners of their own products? Everyone knows they have not done this, and have never even tried. We are by no means saying that the trade unions are useless because they have not done this. On the contrary, the trade unions in England, as in every other industrial country, are necessary for the working class's struggle against capital. The average wage is equal to the amount of the necessities of life required to keep the workers of a country going, generation after generation, according to the general standard of living of that country. For the different strata of workers, this standard of living may differ greatly. The great merit of the trade unions in the struggle to maintain a certain level of wages and shorten the working day lies in their striving to maintain and raise the standard of living. — Marx, *Wages, Price and Profit*

Lenin, from the standpoint of political struggle, put forward that the trade union is the only road by which the working class moves toward unity — there is no other road.

In the early period of capitalist development, the formation of trade unions was a great step forward for the working class, the transition of the workers from a scattered, helpless state to the rudimentary class unity. When the highest form of class unity of the proletariat — the revolutionary party of the proletariat (and the party does not deserve this name if it does not learn to combine leaders and class, leaders and masses, into a single inseparable whole) — begins to grow, the trade unions inevitably reveal certain reactionary features, a certain craft narrowness, a certain tendency to be non-political,

and certain ingrained conservative habits. But apart from through the trade unions, through the trade unions' coordinated action with the party of the working class, the proletariat has never had, and cannot have, any other road of development anywhere in the world. — Lenin, "Left-Wing" Communism: An Infantile Disorder

The globalisation of capitalist production gives the freely flowing capital an enormous advantage over the working classes, which are relatively fixed in the nation-states. If the workers' movement rises in one country while other countries still have vast numbers of peasants entering the cities for work, capital need only make one industrial transfer to solve the problem. The precondition of the development of the workers' movement is that industry still exists; if the factories are all closed, how can the workers' movement develop? Hence, only when this particular mode of capital accumulation, which sets the workers of all countries against one another, comes to an end, can the space for a historic rebound of the workers' movement take shape. In the course of struggling against the same transnational capital employer, the proletariats of all countries will quickly recognise the identity of their interests and move toward unity. At that time, the transnational proletariat will truly become a class for itself. According to the conclusions of the previous section, this mode of capital accumulation will fall into stagnation around 2065; on this forecast, from the 2050s the global workers' movement can gradually welcome its historic rebound. Just as the proletariat within the West European nation-states developed rapidly in the second half of the nineteenth century (1870–1900), the global transnational proletariat will enter a fast track of all-round development — in consciousness, economic organisation, and even political organisation.

Notes

[1] Marx, Capital, Volume I, Chapter 24, "The So-Called Primitive Accumulation" (marxists.org Chinese text)

中文原文：《资本论》第一卷，第二十四章 所谓原始积累

<https://www.marxists.org/chinese/marx-engels/23/036.htm>

[2] Li Bozhong: "Why Can't China's Economic Development Do Without the External World?" (Chinese Social Sciences Network)

中文原文：李伯重：为什么中国经济发展离不开外部世界？

http://jds.cssn.cn/newzxd/t202101/t20210128_5304528.shtml

[3] "Foreign Investment in Modern China: Scale and Effects Analysis" (Peking University NSD)

中文原文：近代外国在华投资：规模与效应分析

<https://www.nsd.pku.edu.cn/attachments/824ec62c198f4245b7013762aebd4ba5.pdf>

[4] "The secret history of IBM's participation in Nazi Germany's 'Final Solution'" (Sina Military)

中文原文：美IBM公司参与纳粹德国“最后解决”秘闻大曝光

<https://mil.news.sina.com.cn/2001-03-31/17235.html>

[5] By 1939, commercial ties between America and Germany were already very close; many American commercial and financial giants had vast interests in Germany. Decades later, the American historian Charles Higham wrote a book on this very subject, Trading with the Enemy. The book says that the Trading with the Enemy Act passed by America in 1917, banning commercial dealings with Germany, could not stop American companies from seeking gold in Germany; Hitler's war machine was armed by Americans. By the mid-1930s, 26 of America's 100 largest companies were actively involved in Nazi activities in Germany and had established close ties with Hitler. And especially astonishing, this continued even after America entered the war. — "American big companies supplied Germany with oil, bombs and other materials during WWII" (Sina News)

中文原文：1939年时，美国与德国之间的商业联系已经十分紧密，多家美国商业和金融巨头都在德国拥有庞大的利益。几十年后，一位名为查尔斯·海厄姆的美国历史学家还曾专门以此为主题创作了《与敌国贸易》一书。该书称，一战期间(1917年)，美国通过的禁止与德国进行商业往来的《与敌国贸易法》丝毫不能阻止美国公司赴德国淘金，希特勒的战争机器正是由美国人武装起来的。该书还介绍称，到20世纪30年代中期，在美国100家最大的公司中已经有26家在德国积极参与纳粹活动，并凭此与希特勒建立了紧密联系。而且尤其让人感到惊愕的是，这种现象一直存在着，即使美国已经参加到战争中。《美国大公司二战时曾向德国提供石油炸弹等物资》

<https://news.sina.cn/sa/2011-02-15/detail-ikftpnnny4570069.d.html?vt=4>

[6] "Value-Added Trade and Regionalization," GTAP Eleventh Annual Conference 'Future of Global Economy', Helsinki, Finland

中文原文：Value-Added Trade and Regionalization. GTAP Eleventh Annual Conference 'Future of Global Economy', Helsinki, Finland

<https://sciencespo.hal.science/hal-01065996/document>

[7] "Trade in intermediates and economic policy" (CEPR VoxEU)

中文原文：Trade in intermediates and economic policy

<https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/trade-intermediates-and-economic-policy>

[8] "Japan's 2024 Trade White Paper shows: more than half of the imports of 1,406 product categories come from China" (CCTV News)

中文原文：日本政府2024年版《通商白皮书》显示：日本1406个品类商品超一半进口额来自中国

<https://news.cctv.com/2024/07/11/ARTI3KYM3KildARcItIoQcXc240711.shtml>

[9] "How big is the impact of China's export controls on dual-use items to Japan?" (Securities Times)

中文原文：中国对日两用物项出口管制影响有多大

<https://www.stcn.com/article/detail/3582827.html>

[10] "America is heavily dependent on China for drug raw materials" (The New York Times Chinese)

中文原文：美国严重依赖中国药品原材料

<https://cn.nytimes.com/usa/20251016/us-drugs-china-production/>

[11] "US report: the American defence industrial base depends on Chinese suppliers" (Sina Finance)

中文原文：美报告：美国国防工业基础依赖中国供应商

<https://finance.sina.com.cn/roll/2025-07-03/doc-infeeerr3636626.shtml>

[12] "Vertical Intra-Industry Trade and the Division of Labor in East Asia" (Hitotsubashi University IER)

中文原文：Vertical Intra-Industry Trade and the Division of Labor in East Asia

[13] "Is China decoupling from the global value chain? A quantitative analysis framework based on the global production network": In recent years, frequent global emergencies have disrupted international stability, prompting countries to decouple from global value chains (GVCs), raising the key question of how to restore and manage this decoupling to reduce risk. From a systems-science perspective, this paper builds a global industrial value chain network model based on multi-regional input-output data, and proposes a theoretical framework for quantitatively assessing the degree of decoupling of economies and industries in the GVC. Taking America's newly introduced trade remedy measures as an example, it analyses their impact on China and the key "transit" countries in the global trade network. The analysis shows that industries highly dependent on intermediate-product trade are more stable in the face of global economic turmoil than resource-based industries. Moreover, highly integrated developed economies show strong resilience by effectively using external resources. Despite the impact of COVID-19, China's connections in the global value chains were actually strengthened, reflecting its adaptability. The results also show that China's emphasis on domestic circulation enhances its ability to withstand Western trade challenges; and multilateral trade agreements and "back-door" export strategies are effective short-term measures to circumvent US trade restrictions. (Nature Humanities and Social Sciences Communications)

中文原文：Is China decoupling from the global value chain? A quantitative analysis framework based on the global production network 近年来，频繁发生的全球性突发事件扰乱了国际稳定，促使各国脱离全球价值链（GVC），由此引发了如何恢复和管理这种脱钩程度以降低风险的关键问题。本文从系统科学视角出发，基于多区域投入产出数据构建了全球产业价值链网络模型，并提出了一个定量评估全球价值链中各经济体和产业脱钩程度的理论框架。本文以美国新出台的贸易救济措施为例，分析了这些措施对中国以及全球贸易网络中的关键“过境”国家的影响。分析表明，与资源型产业相比，高度依赖中间产品贸易的产业在全球经济动荡面前表现出更强的稳定性。此外，高度一体化的发达经济体通过有效利用外部资源展现出强大的韧性。尽管受到新冠疫情的影响，中国在全球价值链中的联系反而得到加强，体现了其适应能力。研究结果还表明，中国对国内流通的重视增强了其抵御西方贸易挑战的能力。此外，多边贸易协定和“后门”出口策略是规避美国贸易限制的有效短期措施。

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41599-025-05183-2>

[14] "Characterizing Global Value Chains: Production Length and Upstreamness": Our empirical results differ from the existing literature in a number of ways. First, we show that emerging economies such as China experience a lengthening of the overall production chains over time. Because the lengthening by these countries dominates shortening of production by others, for the world as a whole, the production line has become longer over time. (NBER)

中文原文：《CHARACTERIZING GLOBAL VALUE CHAINS: PRODUCTION LENGTH AND UPSTREAMNESS》 Our empirical results differ from the existing literature in a number of ways. First, we show that emerging economies such as China experience a lengthening of the overall production chains over time. Because the lengthening by these countries dominates shortening of production by others, for the world as a whole, the production line has become longer over time.

https://www.nber.org/system/files/working_papers/w23261/w23261.pdf

[15] "Global Value Chain Development Report 2025: Rewiring GVCs in a Changing Global Economy": This trend intensified between 2022 and 2024, as major global trade developments ignited widespread reallocation of trade flows. An extended lengthening was recorded in 45 economies (62.5%), with significant expansions noted across Europe (18 economies), Asia and the Pacific (19 economies), as well as all economies within the MENA region. The sharpest increases occurred in Mongolia (10.5%), the Republic of Korea (9.6%) and Bhutan (7.8%), setting a record of lengthening across all time periods, while North American economies saw a shortening of production lengths (by 1–2%). Across the entire period, 16 economies (22%) recorded persistent lengthening. These include European economies such as Belarus, Bulgaria, Croatia, Georgia, Romania and the Russian Federation, along with Egypt,

India, Kuwait, New Zealand, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Sri Lanka. In MENA, the ongoing increase may indicate both diversification and logistical disruptions. On the other hand, only three economies consistently shortened their GVC production lengths: Taipei, China (by 4.04%), the Lao PDR (4.43%) and the PRC (4.75%). (WTO)

中文原文：《GLOBAL VALUE CHAIN DEVELOPMENT REPORT 2025：REWIRING GVCs IN A CHANGING GLOBAL ECONOMY》 This trend intensified between 2022 and 2024, as major global trade developments ignited widespread reallocation of trade flows. An extended lengthening was recorded in 45 economies (62.5%), with significant expansions noted across Europe (18 economies), Asia and the Pacific (19 economies), as well as all economies within the MENA region. The sharpest increases occurred in Mongolia (10.5%), the Republic of Korea (9.6%) and Bhutan (7.8%), setting a record of lengthening across all time periods, while North American economies saw a shortening of production lengths (by 1-2%). Across the entire period, 16 economies (22%) recorded persistent lengthening. These include European economies such as Belarus, Bulgaria, Croatia, Georgia, Romania and the Russian Federation, along with Egypt, India, Kuwait, New Zealand, Pakistan, This trend intensified between 2022 and 2024, as major global trade developments ignited widespread reallocation of trade flows. An extended lengthening was recorded in 45 economies (62.5%), with significant expansions noted across Europe (18 economies), Asia and the Pacific (19 economies), as well as all economies within the MENA region. The sharpest increases occurred in Mongolia (10.5%), the Republic of Korea (9.6%) and Bhutan (7.8%), setting a record of lengthening across all time periods, while North American economies saw a shortening of production lengths (by 1-2%). Across the entire period, 16 economies (22%) recorded persistent lengthening. These include European economies such as Belarus, Bulgaria, Croatia, Georgia, Romania and the Russian Federation, along with Egypt, India, Kuwait, New Zealand, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Sri Lanka. In MENA, the ongoing increase may indicate both diversification and logistical disruptions, which will be discussed further below. On the other hand, only three economies consistently shortened their GVC production lengths: Taipei,China (by 4.04%), the Lao PDR (4.43%) and the PRC (4.75%).

https://www.wto.org/english/res_e/booksp_e/gvcreport2025_e.pdf

[16] "\$600 trillion of wealth rests on productivity or inflation burst" (Reuters)

中文原文：\$600 trillion of wealth rests on productivity or inflation burst

<https://www.reuters.com/markets/europe/600-trillion-wealth-rests-productivity-or-inflation-burst-2025-10-09/>

[17] "SSU professor explores impacts of global power and wealth in new book": Between 2016 and 2017, the number of individuals with as much wealth as half the world's population fell from 62 to just eight, according to Oxfam International. Even more staggering is that just 17 global investment companies control close to \$41 trillion in capital. Sonoma State professor Peter Phillips addresses some of these major shifts in power and wealth in his first solo-authored book "Giants: The Global Power Elite," which identifies who the elite are who are facilitating world capitalism and how their companies protect the status quo from changing. Phillips attempts to shed light on how this collective of billionaires uses its network of influence to suppress social movements and what can be done to push back.

中文原文：《SSU professor explores impacts of global power and wealth in new book》 Between 2016 and 2017, the number of individuals with as much wealth as half the world's population fell from 62 to just eight, according to Oxfam International. Even more staggering is that just 17 global investment companies control close to \$41 trillion in capital. Sonoma State professor Peter Philips addresses some of these major shifts in power and wealth in his first solo-authored book "Giants: The Global Power Elite." "Giants: The Global Power Elite" identifies who the elite are who are facilitating world capitalism and how their companies protect the status quo from changing. With this information readers can pinpoint how these individuals, and their firms, influence major world decisions through their wealth. Phillips attempts to shed light on how this collective of billionaires use its network of influence to suppress social movements and what can be done to push back.

<https://news.sonoma.edu/article/ssu-professor-explores-impacts-global-power-and-wealth-new-book>

[18] "2025 Forbes Global 2000" (Forbes)

中文原文：2025年福布斯2000

[19] Guangming Online, "China Will Long Remain a Fertile Land for Foreign Enterprises to Invest and Thrive": Wang Ya, head of the Foreign Investment Administration of the Ministry of Commerce, recently noted that 2026 is the opening year of the "15th Five-Year Plan"; China will unswervingly expand high-level opening up and strive to create new advantages in attracting foreign investment. It will deepen the reform of the foreign investment promotion system, polish the "Invest in China" brand, fully implement the strategy of upgrading the pilot free-trade zones, and focus on four areas of work: optimising foreign investment support policies — implementing tax credits for foreign investors reinvesting profits earned in China, the catalogue of encouraged industries for foreign investment, and other policy measures, treating foreign enterprises equally in consumption-boosting, government procurement, and bidding activities, helping them develop deeply in China for the long term. (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：光明网 《中国将长期成为外资企业投资兴业的沃土》 商务部外国投资管理司负责人王亚日前指出，2026年是“十五五”的开局之年，我国将坚定不移扩大高水平对外开放，着力塑造吸引外资新优势。深化外商投资促进体制机制改革，擦亮“投资中国”品牌，全面深入实施自贸试验区提升战略，重点做好四方面工作。优化外商投资支持政策。我国将落实好境外投资者以在华取得的利润直接投资税收抵免、鼓励外商投资产业目录等政策措施，一视同仁支持外资企业参与提振消费、政府采购、招投标等活动，助力外资企业在华长期深耕发展。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1855589700134565477&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[20] "Mercedes-Benz CEO reveals: Lutnick invited him to move headquarters to America": The second half of the conversation turned into Lutnick's "sales pitch," as he tried to persuade Källenius to move Mercedes' headquarters to America. Lutnick said: "Doing business in America is great, and it's getting even better," explaining that the new US government "will improve the business environment in every respect — energy, taxes, regulation — and under such conditions, Mercedes' goal is only one: move to America." Källenius acknowledged that the American business environment is generally very good — energy, employment, taxes, and "speed," such as the speed of building factories. It is worth noting that Källenius has repeatedly criticised Germany's bureaucracy and labour costs, and has drawn the ire of unions and worker representatives for publicly citing excessive employee sick-leave rates. However, Källenius pointed out that moving Mercedes to America is unrealistic, for political as well as cultural and traditional reasons. (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：《梅赛德斯-奔驰CEO透露：卢特尼克曾邀其将总部迁至美国》 但谈话的后半部分变成了卢特尼克的“推销”环节，他开始试图说服康林松将梅赛德斯总部迁往美国。卢特尼克说：“在美国做生意很棒，而且还在变得越来越棒。”并解释说，美国新政府“将在各个方面改善营商环境——能源、税收、监管——在这样的条件下，梅赛德斯的目标只有一个：搬到美国。”康林松承认，美国的商业环境总体上非常好，无论是能源、就业、税收，亦或是“速度”，例如建造工厂的速度。值得一提的是，康林松曾多次批评德国的官僚体系和劳动力成本，并因公开提及员工病假率过高而引发工会与员工代表的不满。然而，康林松指出，梅赛德斯迁往美国是不现实的，这不仅有政治原因，也是出于文化和传统原因。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1855584054503681367&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[21] Recently, Egypt's Minister of Investment and Foreign Trade Hassan El-Khatib said Egypt is working to create a more competitive and attractive investment environment for domestic and foreign investors, simplifying approval procedures and removing investment obstacles to attract more investment and raise Egypt's international competitiveness. According to UNCTAD reports, Egypt has been Africa's number one investment destination for two consecutive years; in 2023 it attracted 18.6% of Africa's total FDI, the highest on the continent. Egypt has abundant labour resources and advantages in attracting labour-intensive manufacturing FDI. Its domestic market is also large and can radiate to other African and Middle Eastern countries, providing broad space for foreign enterprises. Egypt is currently increasing its efforts to attract foreign investment through a series of reforms, aiming to become the centre for attracting foreign investment in Africa and the Middle East. It is promoting legislation and reforms in related fields to continuously optimise the investment environment, and providing tax breaks and financing facilities

for specific industries and projects, especially new-energy projects such as green hydrogen. (Jinhua Municipal Commerce Bureau)

中文原文：近日，埃及投资和外贸部部长哈桑·哈提卜表示，埃及正努力为国内外投资者创造更具竞争力和吸引力的投资环境，通过简化审批程序、消除投资障碍等，以吸引更多投资，提高埃及的国际竞争力。根据联合国贸易和发展会议相关报告，埃及已连续两年成为非洲第一大投资目的地，2023年埃及吸引外国直接投资额占非洲吸引外国直接投资总额的18.6%，居非洲国家之首。埃及劳动力资源丰富，在吸引制造业等劳动密集型产业的外资上具有优势。同时，埃及国内市场规模较大，可辐射非洲和中东其他国家，为外资企业发展提供了广阔空间。当前，埃及正通过一系列改革举措，加大吸引外资的力度，致力于成为非洲和中东地区吸引外资的中心。埃及政府推进立法和相关领域改革，不断优化引资环境。埃及政府还为特定行业 and 项目，尤其是绿氢等新能源项目提供税收减免政策和融资便利举措。

http://swj.jinhua.gov.cn/art/2025/2/27/art_1229155874_58925437.html

[22] "Set up the company first, obtain the licence later" is the most core change of Vietnam's new investment policy. Under the new law, the foreign investment process has been fundamentally adjusted. In the traditional model, foreign investors first needed investment approval and an investment registration certificate before establishing an entity. The new law allows foreign investors to establish the company directly before obtaining an investment licence. This reform greatly lowers the threshold and time cost of entering the Vietnamese market. At present, only a few sensitive industries — defence, airports, ports, telecom, publishing — require prior "investment approval"; all other industries follow the principle of "register the company first, make up the licence later." (Zhejiang YER)

中文原文：“先设企、后补证”是越南投资新政最核心的变化。根据新法，外商投资流程发生了根本性调整。传统模式下，外国投资者需要先获得投资主张批准和投资登记证，才能设立企业实体。新法则允许外国投资者在获得投资许可证前直接设立企业。这一改革大幅降低了外资进入越南市场的门槛和时间成本。目前，仅国防、机场、港口、电信、出版等少数敏感行业需要事前“投资主张批准”，其余行业一律适用“先办公司、后补执照”的原则。

<http://www.zyehr.com/h-nd-834.html>

[23] "Germany increases efforts to attract foreign investment": The German government has established multiple economic parks and free-trade zones, adopting tax incentives, simplified approval procedures, and optimised business environments to attract foreign investment, and encourages technological and managerial innovation through R&D subsidies and intellectual property protection. Robert Hermann, COO of Germany Trade & Invest, believes that a stable policy framework, leading innovation capacity, and Europe's largest consumer market are the main reasons Germany maintains strong appeal to foreign investment. Germany Trade & Invest, the federal agency for foreign trade and inward investment, provides consultation and support for foreign companies entering the German market and helps German-established enterprises enter foreign markets. (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：《德国加大外资吸引力度》德国政府设立了多个经济园区和自由贸易区，实施税收优惠、简化审批流程、优化营商环境等政策措施积极吸引外资，还通过提供研发补贴和知识产权保护等鼓励企业进行技术和管理创新。德国联邦外贸与投资署首席运营官罗伯特·赫尔曼认为，稳定的政策框架、领先的创新能力和欧洲最大消费市场等优势，是德国保持较强外资吸引力的重要原因。作为德国联邦政府对外贸易和对内引资的机构，德国联邦外贸与投资署专门为进入德国市场的外国公司提供咨询和支持，并协助在德成立的企业进入外国市场。一旦投资者明确在德国哪个联邦州投资，该机构会把相关咨询服务转交给相应的地方投资促进机构负责。招商引资是地方投资促进机构的主要工作内容之一。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1832782718126042891&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[24] "Against high tariffs! America's largest business organisation reportedly considering suing the Trump administration": According to two sources with direct knowledge of the discussions, America's biggest business lobbying force is considering suing the Trump administration to stop the high reciprocal tariffs set to take effect on Wednesday (9 April). The United States Chamber of Commerce, the world's largest business federation, represents millions of American businesses of all sizes and has long been funded heavily by industry giants. According to insiders, the organisation has recently been weighing whether to take the tariff fight to court, and some of its largest

members are urging it to do so. The move would in effect provide a protective umbrella for enterprises anxious about the tariff shock but afraid to publicly criticise the president's trade policy for fear of retaliation. (CLS)

中文原文：《反对高额关税！美国最大商业组织据悉考虑起诉特朗普政府》财联社4月8日讯（编辑 潇湘）据两位直接了解相关讨论的消息人士透露，美国企业界最大的游说力量正在考虑起诉特朗普政府，以阻止将于周三(4月9日)生效的高额对等关税的实施。美国商会（United States Chamber of Commerce）是全球最大的企业联合会组织，代表着美国数百万大大小小的企业，同时长期以来也一直得到着行业巨头的大量资助。据知情人士透露，该组织近来一直在权衡是否将关税之争诉诸法庭，其一些最大的成员也正在敦促这样做。此举实质上将为那些对关税冲击业务感到焦虑、却又害怕公开批评总统贸易政策会招致报复的企业提供保护伞。其中一位人士指出，其他团体也有可能与美国商会一起提起诉讼。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1828800886213470139&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[25] "Trump tariff threats trigger asset sell-off! America suffers a 'triple kill' of stocks, bonds, and currency": Trump's tariff threats triggered a sell-off of American assets. Overnight, the US market experienced a "triple kill" of stocks, bonds, and currency. Specifically, the three major US stock indices all fell — the Dow fell 1.76%, the S&P 500 more than 2%, and the tech-heavy Nasdaq Composite 2.39%. In addition, the dollar index, which measures the dollar against six major currencies, fell 0.41% to close at 98.642, near a two-week low. (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：《特朗普关税威胁引发资产抛售！美国遭遇“股债汇三杀”》特朗普的关税威胁引发了美国资产的抛售潮。隔夜，美国市场经历了“股债汇三杀”。具体来看，美国三大股指全线下跌，道琼斯工业平均指数下跌1.76%，标普500指数下挫超2%，以科技股为主的纳斯达克综合指数下挫2.39%。此外，衡量美元对六种主要货币的美元指数下跌0.41%，收于98.642，处于大约两周以来的低点。

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1854924335500225050&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[26] "After Nexperia was taken over by the Netherlands, China issued an export ban" (Baidu Baijiahao)

中文原文：安世半导体被荷兰接管后 中国发布出口禁令

<https://baijiahao.baidu.com/s?id=1846006306563268088&wfr=spider&for=pc>

[27] "The Foreign Investment Law of the People's Republic of China — policy interpretation" (Wuhai Municipal Commerce Bureau)

中文原文：《中华人民共和国外商投资法》-政策解读

<http://swj.wuhai.gov.cn/swj/843439/843564/843569/843637/1379925/index.html><http://swj.wuhai.gov.cn/swj/843439/843564/843569/843637/1379925/index.html>

[28] "Accelerating the improvement of China's system for protecting the overseas investment of Chinese enterprises" (Jingji Daokan)

中文原文：加快完善我国企业海外投资保护体系

<https://www.jingjidaokan.com/icms/null/null/ns:LHQ6LGY6LGM6MmM5ZTg1NTc5YjA3ZmZmMjAxOWIoZTVlYzBkYzAwMTIs cDosYTosbTo=/show.vsmI>

[29] "Apple invests \$100 million in Indonesia to build a plant, per Indonesia's demand, to resolve the iPhone 16 sales ban" (Lianhe Zaobao)

中文原文：苹果应印尼要求投资 1 亿美元在该国建厂，以解 iPhone 16 禁售之困

<https://www.zaobao.com/realtime/china/story20250321-6050367>

[30] "Niger expels three Chinese executives of oil companies over wage gap" (RFI Chinese)

中文原文：尼日尔因薪资差距 驱逐油企三中国高管

<https://www.rfi.fr/cn/%E5%9B%BD%E9%99%85/20250314-%E5%B0%BC%E6%97%A5%E5%B0%94%E9%A9%B1%E9%80%903%E5%90%8D%E4%B8%AD%E5%9B%BD%E5%85%AC%E5%8F%B8%E9%AB%98%E7%AE%A1-%E9%99%9048%E5%B0%8F%E6%97%B6%E7%A6%BB%E5%A2%83>

[31] "Burkina Faso accelerates the nationalisation of natural resources" (World Mining Rights)

中文原文：布基纳法索加快自然资源国有化

<https://www.worldmr.net/MRightTrade/MRightCorpList/Info/2025-09-02/314891.shtml>

[32] "Mali: to whom does the gold belong? Azawad, the junta, and the competition of resource nationalism" (Tencent News)

中文原文：马里：黄金属于谁？阿扎瓦德、军政府与资源民族主义的竞争

<https://news.qq.com/rain/a/20251016A0583N00>

[33] "America cracks down hard on ally companies involved with Iran; Europe worries about being caught between the US and Iran" (The Paper)

中文原文：美对盟友涉伊企业下重手，欧洲担忧夹在美伊间“里外不是人”

https://m.thepaper.cn/yidian_promDetail.jsp?contid=2123959&from=yidian

[34] "China agrees to join international cooperation to fight Somali pirates" (BBC Chinese)

中文原文：中国同意参与国际合作打击索马里海盗

https://www.bbc.com/zhongwen/simp/china/2010/01/100129_somalia_piracy_un_china

[35] "Chinese representative: Security Council resolutions on the Red Sea must not be distorted or abused" (Xinhua)

中文原文：中国代表：安理会有关红海的决议不应被曲解滥用

<https://www.news.cn/world/20260115/ea9dfbc0c44d4a0d9dc01e412ffd403e/c.html>

[36] "There are no winners in trade wars; protectionism is no way out" (Qiushi)

中文原文：贸易战没有赢家，保护主义不是出路

<https://www.qstheory.cn/20250405/df9ab70ee90e4eef8c0053d47c544042/c.html>

[37] "Editorial: the applause for China at Davos is sincere" (Sina Finance)

中文原文：社评：达沃斯为中国响起的掌声很真诚

<https://finance.sina.com.cn/roll/2026-01-21/doc-inhhyskr7202541.shtml?from=ggmp>

[38] "Editorial: why international capital is 'adding positions in China' one after another" (Guangming Online)

中文原文：社评：国际资本为何纷纷“加仓中国”

https://world.gmw.cn/2025-12/15/content_38477681.htm

[39] "German enterprises reinvest in China": Over the past year, German enterprises significantly increased their investment in China. According to estimates by the Cologne-based German Economic Institute (IW), new direct investment totalled over €7 billion — the highest level since 2021, about half higher than in 2024, and above the long-term average of €6 billion a year from 2010 to 2024. Jürgen Matthes, head of IW's international economic policy, finance, and real estate research, said: "On the whole, German enterprises are continuing to expand their business footprint in China, and the pace is accelerating again." In contrast, in the first year of President Donald Trump's second term, German investment in America nearly halved. Another IW study shows that German direct investment in America fell 45% between February and November 2025, to about €10.2 billion. IW also analysed the sources of German direct investment in China: the funds mainly come from the reinvestment of profits of Chinese subsidiaries, not repatriated from Germany. The profits reinvested in China, about €12 billion, far exceed the actual new investment of €7 billion. (RFI Chinese)

中文原文：《德国企业重又投资中国》过去一年，德国企业显著增加了在中国的投资。根据位于科隆的德国经济研究所（IW）的测算，新增直接投资总额超过70亿欧元。这是自2021年以来的最高水平，比2024年高出约一半，也高于2010年至2024年期间年均60亿欧元的长期平均水平。IW国际经济政策、金融与房地产市场研究部门负责人于尔根·马特斯表示：

“从整体来看，德国企业正在继续扩大其在中国的业务布局，而且速度再次加快。”与此相反，在总统唐纳德·特朗普第二个任期的第一年，德国企业对美国的投资几乎减半。IW的另一项研究显示，2025年2月至11月期间，德国对美直接投资下降了45%，降至约102亿欧元。IW还分析了德国在中国直接投资的资金来源。结果显示，这些资金主要来自中国子公司的利润再投资，而并未汇回德国。再投资于中国的利润约为120亿欧元，远高于实际新增的70亿欧元投资。

<https://www.rfi.fr/cn/%E4%B8%AD%E5%9B%BD/20260128-%E5%BE%B7%E5%9B%BD%E4%BC%81%E4%B8%9A%E9%87%8D%E5%8F%88%E6%8A%95%E8%B5%84%E4%B8%AD%E5%9B%BD>

[40] "Global capital 'migration' underway: attitude toward Chinese assets shifts to 'planned allocation': At the start of 2026, Asian tech stocks significantly outperformed US tech stocks, reflecting the deep logic of capital flows: as the Fed enters a rate-cutting cycle and dollar assets lose appeal, international capital is re-evaluating the risk-reward of global asset allocation. The pattern of "funds flowing one-way to America" over the past decade or more is loosening; non-US assets, especially Asian markets, seem to be the "next stop" for foreign investment. In this process, foreign capital's attitude toward Chinese assets is gradually shifting from watch-and-wait to "planned allocation." Several industry insiders say foreign institutions are no longer focusing only on "long-short" strategies but also "long only" strategies. (Securities Times)

中文原文：《全球资本“迁徙”进行时：对中国资产态度转为“计划布局”》2026年开年，亚洲科技股显著跑赢美股科技板块，折射出资金流向的深层逻辑：随着美联储进入降息通道、美元资产吸引力减弱，国际资本正在重新评估全球资产配置的风险与回报关系。过去十余年“资金单向流向美国”的格局正在出现松动，非美资产尤其是亚洲市场，似乎成了外资投资的“下一站”。在此过程中，外资对中国资产的态度也逐渐从观望转为“计划布局”。同时，多位业内人士透露，开年外资机构关注的不再只是“long-short”策略（股票对冲策略），也包括“long only”策略（股票多头策略）。

<https://www.stcn.com/article/detail/3600973.html>

[41] "Indian police arrest over a hundred people as Samsung strike protest 'escalates'" (Tencent News)

中文原文：印度警方抓捕上百人，三星罢工抗议“事态升级”

https://news.qq.com/rain/a/20240916A0606300?suid=&media_id=

[42] "Vietnam anti-China protests turn into burning and smashing of Chinese-funded factories; Taiwanese businesses suffer losses": Cai Wanzhen said Vietnam had dispatched police to suppress the riots, calming the crowd at the scene in hopes of preserving Vietnam's image. As evening fell, many factory gates had been destroyed and protesters could enter and leave freely, making it difficult to guarantee the personal safety the Taiwanese businessmen feared; many described their situation as "fleeing for life." (Guancha)

中文原文：《越南反华游行演变为烧砸中资企业工厂 台商受损》蔡婉真说，越南已出动警察镇压暴动，在现场安抚民众，希望顾及越南形象，平息游行。由于进入晚间许多工厂大门已被破坏，抗议民众可以自由进出，届时就很难确保台商担忧人身安全，不少台商以“逃命”形容目前处境。

https://www.guancha.cn/Neighbors/2014_05_14_229369.shtml

[43] "Indonesian workers protest foreign companies' outsourcing": Thousands of Indonesian workers demonstrated outside the Italian, Japanese, Korean, and Malaysian embassies in Jakarta on the 5th, protesting layoffs, outsourcing, and labour-rights violations by those countries' enterprises. Police estimated 5,000–7,000 demonstrators, mainly from West Java, who gathered in Jakarta and marched to the embassies of Japan and other countries. About 8,200 police officers were deployed. (Qiushi Net)

中文原文：《印尼工人抗议外企外包》 数以千计印度尼西亚工人5日在位于首都雅加达的意大利、日本、韩国和马来西亚大使馆外示威，抗议这些国家的企业裁员、外包雇佣和侵犯劳工权利。 警方估计，示威工人大约5000至7000人，主要来自西瓜哇省，当天在雅加达聚集，游行至日本等国驻印尼使馆外。警方派出约8200名警员维持秩序。

<https://news.12371.cn/2012/12/07/ARTI1354877468995975.shtml>

[44] "Review of the Zambian Chinese-mine riot: three or four hundred people beat any Chinese on sight" (Sina News)

中文原文：赞比亚中资煤矿骚乱回顾:三四百人见中国人就打

<https://news.sina.com.cn/c/2012-08-07/031424918281.shtml>

[45] "From Iraq to Venezuela, the logic of 'win the war, take the oil' plays out again" (China Gold)

中文原文：从伊拉克到委内瑞拉，“赢战争就拿走石油”的逻辑再次上演

<http://gold.cnfol.com/guojiyuanyousc/20260107/31923103.shtml>

[46] Hardt & Negri, "World Order," excerpted from Empire (Douban note)

中文原文：哈特、奈格里 | 世界秩序 节选自《帝国》

https://www.douban.com/note/857119140/?_i=9920328iL-TvX7

[47] William I. Robinson, A Theory of Global Capitalism (2004), Chapter 3, "The Transnational State" (marxists.org Chinese text)

中文原文：〔美〕威廉·I·罗宾逊 《全球资本主义论》（2004）第三章 跨国国家

<https://www.marxists.org/chinese/reference-books/a-theory-of-global-capitalism/03.htm#4>

[48] Ellen Meiksins Wood, "New Imperialism and the Nation-State" (marxists.org Chinese text)

中文原文：新帝国主义与民族国家

<https://www.marxists.org/chinese/ellen-wood/mia-chinese-ellen-wood-20031009.htm>

[49] "The tariff war takes a sudden turn: cross-border e-commerce seeks growth in new markets; supply chains 'hedge their bets'": Besides market diversification on the sales side, the supply-chain side also shows a trend of global layout. Earlier, when tariffs exceeded 100%, factories and cross-border sellers without overseas supply chains were caught off guard, with goods piling up unsold, affecting normal business operations. "Whether cross-border sellers or foreign-trade companies, their essence is doing global trade. Previously, procurement relied mainly on domestic resources. But with tariffs fluctuating repeatedly, supply-chain security has gradually become a key factor enterprises must consider," Li Kai told reporters. Although domestic supply chains will still dominate in the short term, in the long run enterprises will gradually tend to develop overseas supply chains. (Securities Times)

中文原文：《关税战峰回路转：跨境电商新市场抢增量，供应链“两头下注”》除了销售端的市场多元化，供应链端也展现出了全球布局的趋势。此前关税一度超过100%时，没有海外供应链的工厂和跨境卖家措手不及，工厂货物积压不发，对正常的生意运转造成影响。“无论是跨境卖家还是外贸公司，其本质都是从事全球贸易。以往，采购主要依赖国内资源。然而，随着关税的反复波动，供应链安全逐渐成为企业必须考虑的关键因素。”李凯向记者表示，尽管短期内国内供应链仍将占据主导地位，但从长期来看，企业会逐渐倾向于开拓国外供应链。

<https://stcn.com/article/detail/1856627.html>

[50] "The big trend of the global economy: three things that must not be 'underestimated' — Solo Thoughts x Zheng Yongnian", 2024-11-15 (Qiia)

中文原文：全球经济大趋势：三个不能“低估” | 独思录 x 郑永年 郑永年 2024-11-15

<https://www.qiia.org/zh-hans/node/1432>

[51] "The dollar's share of global foreign-exchange reserves falls below 60%" (Yicai)

中文原文：美元全球外汇储备占比跌破60%

<https://www.yicai.com/news/102683004.html>

[52] "The Eurodollar is the true global reserve currency" (Yicai)

中文原文：欧洲美元才是全球储备货币

<https://www.yicai.com/news/102683004.html>

[53] "Miao Yanliang: The Unsolved Mysteries of the International Monetary System": According to Zhang Huaqing's calculations, as of 2022, America's broad international seigniorage was about \$60.3 billion, 0.2% of GDP — comparable to the scale calculated in the 1990s literature. Later estimates have grown ever larger: the 2009 estimate put broad international seigniorage at about 0.7% of US GDP, and by 2012 it was estimated at 1%. The estimated scale keeps growing because, with financial globalisation, America's seigniorage tax base keeps expanding. Dollar seigniorage income mainly includes the seigniorage from newly issued dollars (almost 100%) and the implicit income from the erosion of inflation on dollars held abroad (mainly cash and demand deposits). We estimate that as of 2023 the Eurodollar market is about \$16 trillion; at a 4% inflation rate, the second component alone could reach over \$600 billion a year — more than 2% of US GDP. Of course, since the offshore dollar market can also create credit, this income is not entirely captured by the US government and private sector. But according to Friedman, dollar liquidity is ultimately supplied by the American banking system, and these gains ultimately go into America's pocket. (WeChat article)

中文原文：《缪延亮：国际货币体系的未解之谜》根据张怀清的测算，截至2022年，美国获得的广义国际铸币税约603亿美元，占GDP的0.2%。这一规模与20世纪90年代文献中计算得出的国际铸币税规模相当。后续文献对国际铸币税的估算越来越高，2009年计算的广义国际铸币税约占美国GDP的0.7%，而到了2012年已经估算至1%。美国广义国际铸币税的规模估算持续增加，是因为随着金融全球化，美国国际铸币税的税基在不断扩大。美元铸币税收益主要包括新发行美元带来的铸币税收益（几乎是100%），以及境外持有美元（主要是现金和活期存款）因通胀侵蚀而产生的隐性收益。我们测算，截至2023年，欧洲美元市场规模约为16万亿美元，若按4%的通胀率计算，仅第二部分收益就可达每年6 000多亿美元，与美国GDP的比值超过2%。当然，由于离岸美元市场也可以进行信用创造，这部分收益并非完全由美国政府和私人部门获得。但根据弗里德曼的说法，美元流动性归根结底还是由美国的银行体系提供的，这些收益最后还是进了美国的口袋。

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/DEqxXTfK2yocTlrKaraD7g>

[54] "Ju Jiandong: Why do we need capital-account opening? | Macroeconomics": If the renminbi becomes an international currency and the capital account is opened, the war risk will then depend on the outcome of the conflict. It must be emphasised that while the renminbi capital account remains closed, the purpose of America's waging war is not to win but to solve the dollar problem by creating a financial market monopoly; only when the dollar and the renminbi form a symmetric pattern does the war risk truly depend on the outcome of military conflict — the defeated side's capital flows to the victor. If China can win, it can exchange monetary cooperation for peace. (163.com)

中文原文：《鞠建东：为什么我们需要资本账户开放？ | 宏观经济》若人民币成为国际货币且资本账户开放，此时战争风险将取决于冲突的胜负结果。需要强调的是，在人民币资本账户未开放的情况下，美国发动战争的目的并非取胜，而是通过制造金融市场垄断来解决美元问题；只有当美元与人民币形成对称格局后，战争风险才真正取决于军事冲突的结果——战败方的资本会流向战胜方。若中国能取得胜利，便可通过货币合作换取和平（具体条件此处不再展开）。

<https://www.163.com/dy/article/KJBAOP430530P452.html>

[55] "Participation Level in Global Value Chains" (Transport Geography)

中文原文：Participation Level in Global Value Chains

<https://transportgeography.org/contents/chapter7/freight-transportation-value-chains/participation-global-value-chains/>

[56] The average monthly income of fresh university graduates is steadily rising. Among them, the average monthly income of 2024 bachelor's graduates half a year after graduation was 6,199 yuan. MyCOS's "2025 Chinese Bachelor's Employment Report" and "2025 Chinese Vocational College Employment Report" show the above data. (Sina Finance)

中文原文：应届大学毕业生的平均月薪稳中有升。其中，2024届本科生毕业半年后平均月收入为6199元。麦可思近日发布的《2025年中国本科生就业报告》《2025年中国高职生就业报告》显示了上述数据。

<https://finance.sina.com.cn/wm/2025-06-13/doc-inezxtnw0235411.shtml?froms=ggmp>

[57] Employment Blue Book data show that bachelor's graduates employed in first-tier cities (2021 cohort) earned an average monthly income of 7,332 yuan at graduation; after three years of work (2018 cohort), the average salary reached 11,281 yuan. (Lianhe Zaobao)

中文原文：就业蓝皮书数据显示，在一线城市就业的本科生（2021届）毕业初期月收入为7332元；工作三年后（2018届）的平均薪资可达到11281元。

<https://www.zaobao.com/realtime/china/story20230226-1367182>

[58] By the three major economic regions: graduates employed in the Yangtze River Delta had leading monthly incomes half a year after graduation (2023 bachelor's: 6,691 yuan; vocational: 5,273 yuan) and three years after (2020 bachelor's: 10,387 yuan; vocational: 7,722 yuan). (Yicai)

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中文原文：《A ladder of opportunity: unlocking jobs for today's African youth》Sub-Saharan Africa is undergoing a demographic transition of global proportion. By 2050, the region's population is set to grow from 1.5 billion in 2024 to 2.5 billion, with more than 600 million people joining the working-age population. By then, one in three individuals aged 15-34 globally will be African.

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